

Lessons in Chemistry



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF BONNIE GARMUS

Bonnie Garmus grew up in Seattle before attending University of California, Santa Cruz. There, she received a bachelor's degree in creative writing and aesthetics. For much of her life, Garmus worked as a copywriter and creative director. She has also lived all over the world including Switzerland and Columbia and currently resides in London. Though a lover of literature and writing all her life, *Lessons in Chemistry* is Garmus's first novel. Upon its release, *Lessons in Chemistry* quickly became a hit and spent many weeks on the best-seller weeks. In 2023, *Lessons in Chemistry* was adapted to a miniseries starring Brie Larson and Lewis Pullman.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Related Historical Events: *Lessons in Chemistry* is set against the backdrop of 1960s California, a period and place of significant social change, particularly concerning women's roles in society. The 1960s was a decade marked by the Civil Rights Movement, the rise of second-wave feminism, and significant scientific advancements. Women were fighting for equality and the right to have careers and lives outside of the home, which is a central theme in Garmus's novel. Elizabeth's experiences reflect the gender discrimination that was pervasive during this era, where women were often relegated to supportive or background roles in professional environments, particularly in male-dominated fields like science and technology. Additionally, the 1960s saw a significant evolution in the landscape of television in the United States. This period marked a shift from the entertainment and news dichotomy of the 1950s to programming that increasingly reflected the tumultuous social and political climate. By the end of the decade, nearly all American homes had a television. As such, Elizabeth finds herself in the middle of a new media landscape that is politically charged, and she takes advantage of that opportunity.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Lessons in Chemistry is a work of feminist historical fiction, a popular subgenre in contemporary American literature. Other similar works include novels such as Kristin Hannah's *The Nightingale*, Lauren Wilkinson's *American Spy*, and Sara Donati's *Where the Light Enters*. All three of these novels also feature strong female protagonists who find themselves in positions that men traditionally occupy. Like *Lessons in Chemistry*, they are interested in how gender roles function and how one can subvert them. These contemporary works come from a

tradition of literature that examines and challenges the role of women in society. In American fiction, famous examples include *Little Women*, which features a female character who dreams of being a writer, and Kate Chopin's *The Awakening*, a novel about a woman who struggles to assert herself as an individual in society that conventionally values women only in their roles as wives and mothers. In addition to these works, *Lessons in Chemistry* is full of references to other novels because Madeline, Elizabeth Zott's young daughter, is a voracious reader. In fact, Madeline's name comes from a famous scene in Marcel Proust's *In Search of Lost Time*, where the protagonist eats a madeleine cookie, and its taste mentally transports him back to his childhood. Garmus also references authors that would have been popular and controversial in the 1950s, including Norman Mailer and Vladimir Nabokov. Mailer is most famous for his novel *The Naked and the Dead*, a World War II novel, while Nabokov is best known for his novel *Lolita*, about a pedophile who pursues a relationship with an adolescent girl.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Lessons in Chemistry*
- **When Written:** 2022
- **Where Written:** London
- **When Published:** March 29, 2022
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** Southern California in the 1950s and 1960s
- **Climax:** Avery and Wilson fire Donatti from Hastings and hire Elizabeth to replace him. Avery also reveals to Elizabeth that she is Calvin's biological mother.
- **Antagonist:** Dr. Donatti; Patriarchy
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Row Model. Like her protagonist in *Lessons in Chemistry*, Bonnie Garmus is a great rower and has rowed competitively.

Perseverance. Publishers rejected *Lessons in Chemistry* 98 times before it was finally accepted and became a bestseller.



PLOT SUMMARY

Elizabeth Zott attends UCLA as a PhD candidate where she researches abiogenesis, the study of the origin of life on Earth. One day, Elizabeth's thesis advisor, Dr. Meyers, gets irate when she questions his judgment and attempts to rape her. Elizabeth

fight back by blindly stabbing a **pencil** behind her, which punctures Meyers' large and small intestine. Because of the incident, Elizabeth gets forced out of UCLA, while Meyers gets to keep his position. After leaving UCLA, Elizabeth gets a job at the Hastings Institute where she meets Calvin Evans, a brilliant scientist. Although Elizabeth purposely tries to distance herself from Calvin because she does not want him to receive credit for her work, she finds herself falling in love with him. Eventually, she admits her feelings to Calvin, and the two of them begin dating. Everyone else at the office, including Elizabeth's boss, Dr. Donatti, gossips about their relationship and assumes that Elizabeth is only with Calvin because he is famous. However, Calvin and Elizabeth largely ignore them. Their lives continue to become intertwined when Elizabeth moves in with Calvin and they adopt a dog, Six-Thirty, together.

One day, while Calvin and Six-Thirty are jogging together, a police car backfires and scares Six-Thirty, causing Calvin to stumble and split his skull. Calvin dies of his injuries, and Elizabeth is devastated. After Calvin's funeral, Elizabeth discovers she is pregnant. Elizabeth is horrified at the thought of having kids, but abortion is not an option in the early 1960s, so she goes through with the pregnancy. However, early in the pregnancy, Donatti fires Elizabeth—he never liked her in the first place, and the pregnancy is the perfect excuse to get rid of her. Jobless, Elizabeth struggles to get by. Most of her income comes from other employees at Hastings who secretly visit her to ask for her help with their research.

Eventually, Elizabeth gives birth to her daughter, Madeleine, whom she raises with the help of her neighbor, Harriet Sloane. Harriet is eager to help, not only because Elizabeth needs her, but also because it allows her to get away from her drunk and violent husband, Mr. Sloane. Madeleine quickly grows into a precocious and socially adept young girl. Because Elizabeth needs a job that pays well, she decides to send Madeleine to kindergarten at an early age. Then, she briefly returns to work at Hastings. Donatti only rehires Elizabeth because he has a mysterious donor who is interested in abiogenesis and wants to keep him happy. However, shortly after returning to Hastings, Elizabeth quits again because Donatti belittles her and demotes her from her previous position.

Desperate for money, Elizabeth decides to take a job at the local television station after an encounter with Walter Pine, one of the producers. Together, Elizabeth and Walter create a cooking show called *Supper at Six*, which quickly becomes a national sensation. Although Walter tries to make the show a traditional cooking show at the behest of his boss, Phil Lebensmal, Elizabeth refuses to take instruction from anyone. Although she cooks a meal during every episode, she also spends a lot of time discussing the science of cooking and educating her largely female audience about second-wave feminist ideas. Before long, Phil has had enough, and he calls Elizabeth to his office for a private meeting. There, Phil

attempts to sexually assault Elizabeth after verbally berating her. However, Elizabeth foils the assault by pulling a large butcher's knife out of her purse, the sight of which gives Phil a heart attack. The incident puts Phil in the hospital and then recovery for a prolonged period of time, leading to a promotion for Walter. From that point on, Walter allows Elizabeth to do whatever she likes with her show, and it continues to grow in popularity. Although some magazines write nasty articles about Elizabeth and her past, the public generally loves her, and even the president tunes in to watch her show.

Despite the show's immense success, Elizabeth decides to quit so she can return to her true passion: science. After announcing her retirement from *Supper at Six*, Elizabeth expects to receive a number of calls from people interested in hiring her. However, the calls never come. Then, one day, Elizabeth receives a call from Miss Frask, one of the few allies she made at Hastings. Frask has recently become the head of personnel at Hastings, and she asks Elizabeth to come into the institute the following day. When Elizabeth arrives at Hastings, she sees Frask with the people responsible for funding her abiogenesis research, Parker Avery and Wilson. Avery and Wilson fire Donatti and offer Elizabeth his role at Hastings. However, Elizabeth rejects the offer because she thinks they only want her because of her relationship with Calvin.

Avery takes Elizabeth aside and reveals her true identity and explains why she is interested in Calvin: it turns out that Avery is Calvin's birth mother, whom Calvin long believed to be dead. Avery also thought Calvin was dead because a bishop at the boys' home where he grew up lied in order to receive more funding. Avery only discovered Calvin was alive after he became a famous scientist. In an effort to reconnect with her son, she started funding the Hastings Institute. However, before they could reunite, Calvin tragically died. After hearing Avery's story, Elizabeth accepts the job at Hastings and invites Avery back to her home so she can meet Madeleine.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Elizabeth Zott – Elizabeth Zott is the protagonist of *Lessons in Chemistry* and the mother of Madeline Zott. She is an intelligent, talented, and beautiful young woman, who constantly attacks and subverts the gender norms of her time. She begins her career as a scientist at the Hastings Institute where she meets and falls in love with Calvin Evans. Although Elizabeth enjoys her relationship with Calvin, she does not want to marry him because she does not want to exist in his shadow. Similarly, she does not want children, though she ends up with one anyway. After Calvin's death, Elizabeth becomes a trailblazing social and political commentator through her cooking show, *Supper at Six*. Though the show was designed to

be light entertainment for housewives, Elizabeth uses her platform to educate her viewers on the tenets of second-wave feminism. In addition to her feminist principles, Elizabeth is also an avowed atheist. In general, Elizabeth refuses to hold her tongue when it comes to controversial subjects: she values speaking the truth and doing what is right above all else. Elizabeth's attitudes are infectious and begin to spread toward those around her, such as Walter and Harriet.

Calvin Evans – Calvin Evans is a brilliant young scientist and rowing enthusiast who works alongside Elizabeth at the Hastings Institute. Calvin is a genius with multiple Nobel Prize nominations, and he's one of the most famous scientists in the country. His intelligence is the source of much admiration and jealousy from those around him. In general, Calvin is a good-natured and well-meaning person. Although there are rumors around Hastings that Calvin likes to hold a grudge, the only person he really hates is his biological father, who he believes abandoned him. In reality, Calvin's father died before he was born and never had a chance to care for him, though this fact only comes to light after Calvin's death. Calvin falls in love with Elizabeth after meeting her at Hastings. Although Calvin generally agrees with Elizabeth's socially liberal attitudes, he feels that they should marry and have kids, a position he hopes she will slowly come around to. Unfortunately, Calvin dies in a tragic and random accident before either can happen, though Elizabeth discovers that she is pregnant shortly after his death and goes on to raise their child, Madeline, as a single mother.

Walter Pine – Walter Pine is the father of Amanda Pine and a producer for the local television network. He gives Elizabeth a TV show, *Supper at Six*, after witnessing her passion for nutrition. Although Walter's instincts are more socially conservative than Elizabeth's, Elizabeth repeatedly convinces him to let her do the show the way she wants to. After some encouragement from Elizabeth, Walter also stands up to Phil Lebensmal, his abusive boss. Like Elizabeth, it is important to Walter that he be a good parent and set a good example for his daughter.

Miss Frask – Miss Frask is a young woman whom Elizabeth meets at Hastings. At first, Frask is an unkind woman, who spreads crude rumors about Elizabeth and treats her abhorrently. However, that all changes when she and Elizabeth confide in each other and discover they both experienced sexual assault at the hands of their thesis directors. From that point forward, Miss Frask is always in Elizabeth's corner, and she plays a key role in rehabilitating Elizabeth's public image.

Harriet Sloane – Harriet Sloane is Elizabeth's neighbor who helps raise Madeline. Although Harriet initially aids Elizabeth because she sees a neighbor in need, she is also motivated to help Elizabeth because it allows her time away from her drunk, abusive husband, Mr. Sloane. Temperamentally, Harriet is more reserved and conservative than Elizabeth. Although she does not love her husband, she feels the need to stay in her abusive

marriage. However, eventually, Elizabeth's self-possessed attitude begins to wear off on Harriet, and she begins an affair with Walter, for whom she has developed romantic feelings.

Madeline Zott – Madeline is the daughter of Elizabeth Zott and Calvin Evans. She is a precocious child who enjoys reading and researching in her spare time, despite being only four years old. Madeline does her best not to stand out in school despite being the most impressive person in the class by far. Her interest in her family's history helps Elizabeth discover the truth regarding Calvin's birth parents.

Wakely – Wakely is a reverend whom Calvin used to write to as a young man. By sheer coincidence, Wakely meets Madeline at the library, and they discuss a variety of topics, including religion and family. Despite his profession as a religious leader, Wakely does not believe in God, though he does think that religion can provide people with a useful moral framework.

Avery Parker – Avery Parker is Calvin's biological mother. Calvin was separated from her at birth, and she spent much of her life believing he was dead. When she discovered her son was alive, she did everything she could to find him. She is a compassionate and intelligent woman who wants to be a good grandmother to Madeline since she can no longer be a mother to Calvin.

Dr. Donatti – Dr. Donatti is the head of Elizabeth's department at the Hastings Institute. Donatti hates Elizabeth and regularly belittles her to other people at Hastings. He also fires her when he discovers she is pregnant and lies to the people funding her research about her true identity, claiming that "Dr. Zott" is a man rather than a woman.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Six-Thirty – Six-Thirty is Elizabeth's dog whom she teaches to understand English. After Calvin's death, he serves as Madeline's protector and provides Elizabeth with emotional support. Before becoming Elizabeth and Calvin's dog, Six-Thirty was a bomb-sniffing dog for the military.

Phil Lebensmal – Phil Lebensmal is an executive at the local television station where Elizabeth works. He is a crude and abusive man who attempts to sexually assault Elizabeth. However, Elizabeth halts the attack by pulling a knife out of her purse, the sight of which gives Phil a heart attack.

John Zott – John is Elizabeth's brother, whom she felt a close connection to. He died by suicide when Elizabeth was still a child because his parents emotionally abused him after discovering he was gay.

Elizabeth's Father – Elizabeth's father is a religious charlatan who makes a living by scaring people into believing the apocalypse is coming. After one of his stunts goes wrong, Elizabeth's father ends up killing a few people, which puts him in jail.

Elizabeth's Mother – Elizabeth's mother was Elizabeth father's partner in crime. She fled the country after Elizabeth's father went to jail.

Dr. Meyers – Dr. Meyers is Elizabeth's abusive doctoral thesis advisor. He sexually assaults Elizabeth, who stabs him in the stomach with a pencil in order to escape.

Franklin Roth – Franklin Roth is a reporter who interviews Elizabeth and eventually publishes an article that praises her and her work.

Marjorie Fillis – Marjorie Fillis is a woman who attends a taping of Elizabeth's talk show. Elizabeth convinces her to go back to school so she can achieve her dream to be a heart surgeon.

Dr. Boryweitz – Dr. Boryweitz is a scientist who works at the Hastings Institute. He is bad at his job and regularly comes to Elizabeth for help.

Dr. Mason – Dr. Mason is a kind and understanding man who helps Elizabeth deliver Madeline. He is also the captain of the local rowing team.

The Bishop – The bishop is the man in charge of the boys' home where Calvin grew up. He lies to Wilson and Avery about Calvin, leading them to believe Calvin is dead.

Mrs. Mudford – Mrs. Mudford is Madeline's teacher. She disapproves of how Elizabeth treats her daughter's education and spreads nasty rumors about the Zott family.

Wilson – Wilson is a lawyer, who helps Avery Parker track down Calvin (and eventually Elizabeth).

Amanda Pine – Amanda Pine is Walter's daughter. She and Madeline are school friends.

Mr. Sloane – Mr. Sloane is Harriet's abusive husband, whom she eventually leaves.

pursuit of knowledge and truth set her apart in a world where women's roles were traditionally confined to the domestic sphere. Donatti, Elizabeth's boss, hates that she works for him at Hastings and feels threatened by her intelligence as well as her unconventional views about the role of women in society. Donatti demotes and fires Elizabeth for reasons that have nothing to do with her performance and everything to do with her gender, such as her pregnancy.

Lessons in Chemistry also touches on themes of motherhood and its intersection with career aspirations. Elizabeth's role as a single mother and a professional challenges the stereotypical notion that women must choose between their family and career. Her determination to excel in both realms pushes back against societal expectations that often limit women's choices and potential. Elizabeth is not only a brilliant chemist, but she is also a great mother, friend, educator, and rower. Notably, Elizabeth does not tell women that they do not belong in the home; rather, she tells them that they do not *have* to be in the home. In this regard, her message and the novel's are one in the same: that women have the capability to do whatever they put their minds to, even in societies that want to tell them that the opposite is true.



SCIENCE VS. RELIGION

In *Lessons in Chemistry*, Elizabeth Zott is a chemist whose life and career are guided by the principles of science—rationality, evidence, and experimentation. Her approach to life is deeply empirical, relying on observable and provable facts, which often puts her at odds with the more faith-based aspects of society. Elizabeth's character represents the scientific perspective, emphasizing logic, reason, and the pursuit of knowledge. In contrast, various characters in *Lessons in Chemistry* embody the religious and traditional viewpoints prevalent in that era. These characters often clash with Elizabeth, demonstrating the societal tensions between science and religion. At the mild end of the spectrum, there are the people that make up the audience of Elizabeth's show, most of whom are housewives. These people disagree with Elizabeth's views but respect her enough to continue watching her. On the more extreme end, there are people like the religious extremist who brings a bomb to a taping of *Supper at Six*.

Although the novel does not dismiss the potentially positive moral considerations of religion altogether, it largely argues for the value of a scientific worldview over a religious one. Many of the religious figures in the novel are either corrupt (such as the deacon who ran Calvin's boys' home) or narrowminded (like the people who write to Elizabeth's show). The only seemingly religious figure who the novel portrays sympathetically is Wakely, who eventually admits that he does not believe in God. Meanwhile, Elizabeth and Calvin's atheistic views are presented as sound, rational, and without flaw. As such, the



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



GENDER INEQUALITY

Lessons in Chemistry offers an exploration of women's roles in society during the mid-twentieth century. At the heart of the novel is the protagonist, Elizabeth Zott, whose journey is not just a personal tale, but a reflection of the broader struggles and societal expectations that women faced during that era. Elizabeth Zott is a character who defies the norms of her time. As a chemist in the 1950s and 1960s, she faces immense gender discrimination in a male-dominated field. Her passion for science and her unwavering

novel rather unambiguously argues for the value of science over religion.



OVERCOMING TRAGEDY AND TRAUMA

Elizabeth's life is marked by a series of traumatic events, including professional setbacks, sexual assaults, and personal losses. One of the most poignant aspects of her story is the loss of her partner, Calvin Evans, which leaves her a single mother. This loss is a profound turning point in Elizabeth's life, deeply affecting her emotional landscape and her approach to the world around her. The way Elizabeth deals with her traumas is central to the novel's message about a person's ability to heal and move forward in the aftermath of pain and loss. She does not succumb to despair or allow her circumstances to define her. Instead, she channels her pain and experiences into her work and into raising her daughter, Madeline. Elizabeth's resilience is inspiring: she confronts her challenges with a scientific mindset, analyzing problems and devising solutions, whether they pertain to a chemical experiment or to life's obstacles. Although she often feels overwhelmed, Elizabeth does not let the negative aspects of her life keep her down. Rather, she challenges herself and those around her to work to create a better world. For instance, after *Life* magazine publishes a disparaging article about her, Elizabeth uses her next performance on *Supper at Six* to publicly address her unfair treatment and gender discrimination in the workplace. By addressing her problems directly, she not only inspires herself to keep going, but she also sends a positive and socially constructive message to everyone willing to listen. Ultimately, then, the novel's message is that even the worst traumas and adversarial situations can be overcome. Although personal losses will always sting, the novel argues that it's possible to turn adverse circumstances into positive outcomes—and that doing so can be beneficial in the long run.



FAMILY

Lessons in Chemistry challenges traditional notions of what constitutes a family, emphasizing the idea that families are not just formed by blood relations but also by the bonds of love, respect, and mutual support. The protagonist, Elizabeth Zott, finds herself navigating the complexities of family life in an era when society rarely questioned the conventional family model. Elizabeth's family life is far from traditional. As a single mother to her daughter, Madeline, and her dog, Six-Thirty, she represents a non-traditional family unit. However, the novel shows that the essence of family lies in nurturing and caring relationships, rather than in adhering to societal norms or structures.

Elizabeth's relationship with her daughter is central to the novel's exploration of family. Madeline, a bright and curious child, is not just Elizabeth's daughter but also a crucial part of

her life's work and passion for science. Elizabeth's approach to parenting is characterized by teaching Madeline to question, learn, and think independently, reflecting her values as a scientist and as a person. This dynamic illustrates a family bond built on intellectual growth, emotional support, and mutual respect, rather than traditional roles. Moreover, the novel shows how family can extend beyond human relationships. Elizabeth's dog, Six-Thirty, is an integral part of their family, providing companionship and emotional support. This inclusion of a pet as a family member broadens the definition of family, showing how care and affection can transcend species.

Lessons in Chemistry also explores how families can be formed through communities and friendships. Elizabeth's relationships with her colleagues and neighbors contribute to a broader sense of family, offering support and understanding in a world that often seems hostile and challenging. For instance, Elizabeth's neighbor Harriet, who quickly becomes Madeline's babysitter (as well as a maternal figure for Elizabeth herself), is much closer to Elizabeth than either of her biological parents. Similarly, although Elizabeth did not meet Avery, Calvin's biological mother, until well after Calvin's death, she welcomes her into her home—not because she is Calvin's mother, but because she is a good person looking for love and connection.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



ELIZABETH'S PENCIL

Elizabeth's pencil is a symbol of female empowerment, capability, and self-possession. It also shows that change and instability can be possible in an otherwise masculine and unchanging world. The pencil first appears in one of the novel's darkest moments. Seemingly out of nowhere, Elizabeth's doctoral thesis advisor, Dr. Meyers, sexually assaults her. To fight back, Elizabeth grabs a pencil and thrusts it blindly behind her, puncturing Meyers's small and large intestines. In this moment, the pencil functions as a practical tool for Elizabeth to physically defend herself against a man who would otherwise overpower her. From this moment forward, Elizabeth uses a pencil to help keep her hair up. Although the pencil looks innocuous to people who do not know its purpose, it functions as a reminder of Elizabeth's preparedness and potential in a world that wishes to take advantage of her in more ways than one. At one point, Elizabeth says that she prefers pencils to pens because pencils allow for the correction of errors, which is a fundamental and necessary part of scientific inquiry. However, given the novel's interest in the shifting social and political landscapes of the 1950s and 1960s, Elizabeth's preference for pencils also gestures toward

her (and the novel's) belief that society can and should recognize its "mistakes"—its systemic inequalities and flawed social norms—and work to change them.



THE SUPPER AT SIX SET

The *Supper at Six* set represents the broader societal changes of the 1960s and the personal evolution of Elizabeth Zott. The set is a televised stage where Elizabeth breaks the era's gender norms by merging the domestic sphere with science, as she replaces the kitschy 1960s décor of the set with scientific lab equipment. The kitchen, traditionally a space for woman, becomes a laboratory where Elizabeth conducts culinary experiments that serve as accessible cooking and science lessons for her majority-female audience.

In a broader sense, the set signifies transformation. For Elizabeth, it represents a compromise—a step down from her career as a chemist—but also becomes a platform to speak her mind. Over time, Elizabeth grows disillusioned with her role on *Supper at Six* and decides to quit to return to science, a goal she eventually achieves. Throughout the course of the novel, Elizabeth becomes a scientist, then a TV persona who functions as a cook, activist, and educator all in one, before becoming a scientist again. The *Supper at Six* set is the site and catalyst that allows this transformation to take place.

These are the opening lines of Bonnie Garmus's *Lessons in Chemistry*. They encapsulate Elizabeth Zott's internal conflict during the early 1960s, a time when social norms confined women to domesticity. Despite the outward societal optimism of the post-war era, Elizabeth feels a personal despondency, convinced that her life's potential is exhausted now that she is a thirty-year-old mother. Although Elizabeth does not yet know it, she is part of a society on the brink of change—change that she will help bring about over the course of the novel. Elizabeth's experience reflects the broader condition of many women before the feminist movements of the 1960s gained momentum, highlighting the dichotomy between the era's progressive ideals and the reality of gender inequality. This opening paragraph sets the stage for Elizabeth's character, whose personal journey will come to mirror the transformative spirit of the times, as she challenges those around her to evolve.

Chapter 2: Pine Quotes

☞ But then a prominent reporter wrote an article entitled "Why We'll Eat Whatever She Dishes Out" and, in passing, referred to her as "Luscious Lizzie," a nickname that, because it was both apt and alliterative, stuck to her as quickly as it did the paper it was printed on. From that day forward, strangers called her Luscious, but her daughter, Madeline, called her Mom, and although she was just a child, Madeline could already see that the nickname belittled her mother's talents. She was a chemist, not a TV cook. And Elizabeth, self-conscious in front of her only child, felt ashamed.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Madeline Zott

Related Themes:

Page Number: 7

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the end of Chapter 2, as the narrator describes how the media has distorted Elizabeth's career. The nickname "Luscious Lizzie," coined by a reporter, is catchy but reduces Elizabeth's identity to a mere object of attraction for men, overshadowing her professional identity as a scientist. The public's quick adoption of the nickname's demonstrates the pervasive nature of media influence and how it can shape personal narratives, often without the consent of those involved. Even as a child—albeit an extremely precocious one—Madeline recognizes the diminishment of her mother's achievements, understanding that Elizabeth's skills as a chemist far surpass her secondary



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Doubleday edition of *Lessons in Chemistry* published in 2022.

Chapter 1: November 1961 Quotes

☞ Back in 1961, when women wore shirtwaist dresses and joined garden clubs and drove legions of children around in seatbeltless cars without giving it a second thought; back before anyone knew there'd even be a sixties movement, much less one that its participants would spend the next sixty years chronicling; back when the big wars were over and the secret wars had just begun and people were starting to think fresh and believe everything was possible, the thirty-year-old mother of Madeline Zott rose before dawn every morning and felt certain of just one thing: her life was over.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1

Explanation and Analysis

role as a “TV cook.” This awareness contrasts the public’s superficial adoration with the deeper appreciation that comes from knowing Elizabeth personally. The quote also reveals Elizabeth’s vulnerability as she grapples with her public persona. The shame she feels underscores the internal conflict between her professional self-worth and how the public has chosen to trivialize her accomplishments.

Chapter 3: Hastings Research Institute Quotes

☛ “Look, I know it’s not your fault, but they shouldn’t send a secretary up here to do their dirty work. Now I know this might be hard for you to understand, but I’m in the middle of something important. Please. Just tell your boss to call me.”

Related Characters: Calvin Evans (speaker), Elizabeth Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 12

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the first meeting between Elizabeth Zott and Calvin Evans. Calvin is busy working and annoyed that Elizabeth ignored the signs on his office door, asking anyone and everyone to keep out. The moment gets their relationship started on the wrong foot because Calvin assumes Elizabeth is a secretary rather than a scientist, presumably because she is a woman. It is a moment that establishes Calvin—who is a relatively progressive character—as someone who holds biases, whether he realizes it or not. He quickly realizes and regrets his mistake, though not before Elizabeth can slam his office door in his face. The passage also demonstrates how separate Calvin is from everyone else in the office, as Elizabeth has worked at Hastings for some time at this point, yet Calvin fails to recognize her. On the flip side, although Calvin does not intimidate Elizabeth, she is well aware of his identity, just like everyone else in the office.

Chapter 6: The Hastings Cafeteria Quotes

☛ Elizabeth shook her head. “Our future happiness does not depend on whether or not we’re married, Calvin—at least not to me. I’m fully committed to you; marriage will not change that. As for who thinks what, it’s not just a handful of people: it’s society—particularly the society of scientific research. Everything I do will suddenly be in your name, as if you’d done it. In fact, most people will assume you’ve done it simply because you’re a man, but especially because you’re Calvin Evans. I don’t want to be another Mileva Einstein or Esther Lederberg, Calvin; I refuse. And even if we took all the proper legal steps to ensure my name won’t change, it will still change. Everyone will call me Mrs. Calvin Evans; I will *become* Mrs. Calvin Evans.”

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Calvin Evans

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 52

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the scene where Calvin and Elizabeth are arguing in the Hastings Cafeteria about the possibility of marriage. Elizabeth is opposed to marriage due to its implications for her identity and career. Her refusal to marry Calvin is not a rejection of commitment but a refusal to let her commitment to him harm her career. She also asserts that her happiness is not contingent on marital status, challenging the traditional view that marriage is the ultimate goal, especially for women. In addition, she points out the bias in scientific research, citing instances in which the scientific community and the broader public attributed a woman’s work to her husband, particularly one as renowned as Calvin Evans. By referencing Mileva Einstein and Esther Lederberg, she alludes to historical instances where women’s contributions to science may have been obscured because of their husbands’ fame. These examples underline her fears of losing her professional identity and being reduced to “Mrs. Calvin Evans,” regardless of whether she legally maintains her name.

Chapter 7: Six-Thirty Quotes

☛ Rowing a pair with Elizabeth. How glorious!

“No.”

“But why?”

“Because. Women don’t row.” But as soon as she’d said it, she regretted it.

“Elizabeth Zott,” he said, surprised. “Are you actually saying women can’t row?” That sealed it.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Calvin Evans (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 62

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from a conversation Calvin has with Elizabeth about rowing. He is eager for Elizabeth to come row with him, but she is uncharacteristically unsure of herself. The quote captures a moment of contradiction and realization for Elizabeth. The initial exclamation from Calvin suggests his admiration and desire to share in the joy of rowing with her. However, Elizabeth's immediate, reflexive response ("Women don't row") is out of the ordinary for her and reveals that she has some internalized biases of her own. This moment of regret can be seen as Elizabeth catching herself upholding the very stereotypes or limitations she opposes. She has to take a moment to realize what she has said—which Calvin immediately catches—and deconstruct why she said it. Calvin's teasing response makes Elizabeth realize that he caught her in an ideological inconsistency that she knows she cannot let stand. As such, she decides to row with Calvin, and the sport eventually turns into her favorite hobby.

of how woman should behave and what they are capable of. Because Donatti cannot imagine that Elizabeth is succeeding because of her own merits, he invents narratives—all of which are centered around Calvin—to explain her behavior. Donatti is doing exactly what Elizabeth feared the public would do when they learned of her involvement with Calvin; that is, reduce her to "Mrs. Calvin Evans" rather than treat her as an independent person with her own hopes, dreams, and accomplishments. Unfortunately, Donatti is in charge at Hastings, and his dislike of Elizabeth and her behavior has negative consequences for her as the novel progresses. Even when Elizabeth is successful, Donatti finds ways to knock her down, sabotaging not only Elizabeth but the success of the Hastings Institute, to satisfy his ego.

Chapter 12: Calvin's Parting Gift Quotes

☝☝ Now, sitting rigidly on her stool in the lab, she could hear a policeman talking about someone who'd died and someone else insisting she take his handkerchief and still another saying something about a vet, but all she could think about was that moment long ago when her toes had touched bottom, the soft, silky mud inviting her to stay. Knowing what she knew now, she could only think one thing: I should have.

Chapter 8: Overreaching Quotes

☝☝ This was the other thing he hated about Zott: she was tireless. Stiff. Didn't know when to quit. Standard rower attributes, now that he thought about it. He hadn't rowed in years. Was there really a women's team in town? Obviously, she couldn't possibly be rowing with Evans. An elite rower like Evans would never deign to get in a boat with a novice, even if they were sleeping together. Scratch that; especially if they were sleeping together. Evans probably signed her up for some beginner crew, and Zott, wanting to prove that she could hold her own—per usual—went along with it.

Related Characters: Dr. Donatti (speaker), Elizabeth Zott, Calvin Evans

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 71

Explanation and Analysis

In this quote, Dr. Donatti expresses disdain for Elizabeth Zott's tenacity and resilience, traits that he grudgingly acknowledges as common among rowers. Elizabeth's perseverance frustrates Donatti because it challenges ideas

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Calvin Evans, Harriet Sloane, Madeline Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 96

Explanation and Analysis

This quote captures a moment of intense personal crisis for Elizabeth, as she has just learned of Calvin's death. The memory of her toes touching the soft mud represents a past moment when Elizabeth almost drowned as a child. The mud's "inviting" quality suggests the allure of surrendering to death, of letting go rather than enduring the struggle. In other words, when Elizabeth thinks "I should have," she is speaking of suicide. Elizabeth is feeling suicidal not just because Calvin is dead, but also because she feels responsible for his death and does not think she will ever be able to forgive herself. Although Elizabeth's suicidal thoughts rarely come up again in the story—largely because her pregnancy and TV show distract from them—this is an important moment for her character because it lays bare the depths of her grief. Throughout the rest of the novel, she always tries to put on a brave face for Harriet and Madeline, as well as the many women who she speaks to

during *Supper at Six*.

Chapter 14: Grief Quotes

☹☹ Crouching, he waited for the man to leave, then relaxed his body down the length of the casket buried below. *Hello, Calvin.*

This is how he communicated with humans on the other side. Maybe it worked; maybe it didn't. He used the same technique with the creature growing inside Elizabeth. *Hello, Creature*, he transmitted as he pressed his ear into Elizabeth's belly. *It's me, Six-Thirty. I'm the dog.*

Related Characters: Six-Thirty (speaker), Elizabeth Zott, Calvin Evans, Madeline Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 118

Explanation and Analysis

In this scene, Six-Thirty engages in an act of communication that transcends the ordinary, reaching out to both the living and the dead. At this point, Elizabeth is pregnant with Madeline and Six-Thirty feels it is his duty to look after her as he looks out at Calvin's grace. Six-Thirty is an interesting addition to the novel because his capabilities place his segments into something akin to magical realism, which is quite out of place for a novel that otherwise preaches the gospel of science. In this scene, he attempts to communicate with both the recently deceased and the someone who has yet to be born. Perhaps his narration can be understood as an exaggerated version of the intense bonds that form between people and their pets. Regardless, this is a moment in which Six-Thirty forms an unbreakable bond with Madeline. Once she is born, he rarely leaves her side and remains loyal to her under all circumstances.

Chapter 15: Unsolicited Advice Quotes

☹☹ It was the seventh time that week someone felt compelled to inform her that her life was about to change and she was sick of it. She'd lost her job, her research, bladder control, a clear view of her toes, restful sleep, normal skin, a pain-free back, not to mention all the little assorted freedoms everyone else who is not pregnant takes for granted—like being able to fit behind a steering wheel. The only thing she'd gained? Weight.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 125

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Elizabeth expresses frustration and fatigue over the constant reminders of how pregnancy is altering her life. The passage highlights the pervasive nature of change during pregnancy, not just physically but also in terms of lifestyle and professional identity. The list of losses she goes through—her job, research, various aspects of physical comfort and autonomy—enumerates the sacrifices that come with being pregnant, particularly as a working woman. The “clear view of her toes” is a humorous representation of her body's physical changes, while the loss of “all the little assorted freedoms” points to a deeper sense of confinement that can accompany pregnancy. The only gain she sarcastically notes is “Weight,” while she has literally gained weight, her observation is also a nod to the symbolic weight of the emotional burden she is carrying. Of course, those who have commented on Elizabeth's condition do not make her feel any better. If anything, their comments make her feel more alone.

Chapter 17: Harriet Sloane Quotes

☹☹ “Take a moment for yourself,” Harriet said. “Every day.” “A moment.”

“A moment where you are your own priority. Just you.

Not your baby, not your work, not your dead Mr. Evans, not your filthy house, not anything. Just you. Elizabeth Zott. Whatever you need, whatever you want, whatever you seek, reconnect with it in that moment.” She gave a sharp tug to her fake pearls. “Then recommit.”

Related Characters: Harriet Sloane (speaker), Elizabeth Zott, Calvin Evans

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 147

Explanation and Analysis

This passage depicts the scene in which Harriet and Elizabeth formally meet each other for the first time. Harriet had to come and wake Elizabeth up because she was passed out on the floor of her home from exhaustion. Harriet's advice to Elizabeth emphasizes the necessity of taking time for oneself, even if it is just a moment each day. Harriet explains that this time is not meant for one's responsibilities or worries, such as caring for a baby, work obligations, past losses, or household chores. Instead, it's a

dedicated time for Elizabeth to focus solely on herself—to attend to her own needs. Harriet's advice underlines the concept of self-rediscovery and reconnection, suggesting that by doing so, Elizabeth can find the strength and clarity she needs to continue doing her job as a mother. Harriet presents this moment of self-prioritization as a form of emotional and mental recalibration—a way for Elizabeth to get back in touch with her true self before stepping back into the hectic world of motherhood.

Chapter 18: Legally Mad Quotes

☛ So, sometime after it was all over, when a nurse came in with a stack of papers demanding to know something—how she felt?—she decided to tell her.

“Mad.”

“Mad?” the nurse had asked.

“Yes, mad,” Elizabeth had answered. Because she was. “Are you sure?” the nurse had asked.

“Of course I’m sure!”

And the nurse, who was tired of tending to women who were never at their best—this one had practically engraved her name on her arm during labor—wrote “Mad” on the birth certificate and stalked out.

So there it was: the baby’s legal name was Mad. Mad Zott.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Calvin Evans, Madeline Zott, Avery Parker

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 152

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Elizabeth thinks back on the bizarre way that Madeline got her legal name: “Mad Zott.” This scene offers a darkly comic twist that underscores the disconnection that can occur in institutional settings like hospitals, where people—particularly single mothers—are not attended to as well as they should be. Later in the novel, Avery (Calvin’s biological mother) also discusses how medical professionals mistreated her, largely because she was a single mother. Elizabeth’s emphatic assertion of her feelings and the nurse’s interpretation highlight the disconnect between the hospital staff and those they are supposed to be caring for. The nurse’s mistake leads to Elizabeth having a child with a deranged-sounding name, which does not help Elizabeth’s fear that her child will turn out abnormal. Luckily, Mad—who Elizabeth calls

Madeline—turns out well despite her unconventional name, going on to become a young genius who is also quite socially adept.

Chapter 24: The Afternoon Depression Zone Quotes

☛ “By the way,” he said, pausing, “have you ever noticed how women always say they need to run to the store? Not walk, not go, not stop by. Run. That’s what I mean. The homemaker is operating at an insane level of hyperproductivity. And even though she’s in way over her head, she still has to make dinner. It’s not sustainable, Elizabeth. She’s going to have a heart attack or a stroke, or at the very least be in a foul mood. And it’s all because she can’t procrastinate like her fourth grader or pretend to be doing something like her husband. She’s forced to be productive despite the fact that she’s in a potentially fatal time zone—the Afternoon Depression Zone.”

Related Characters: Walter Pine (speaker), Elizabeth Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 205-206

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Walter is explaining the psychology behind the TV programming schedule to Elizabeth. Walter notes the language women use when speaking about errands, highlighting the term “run” as an indication of the urgency that characterizes their daily routines. This choice of word reflects a deeper cultural expectation for women to be constantly active, managing their household duties with a high level of intensity. Walter describes this state of hyperproductivity as unsustainable, indicating that the pressure to be constantly productive is a problem. He contrasts this with the perceived ability of children to procrastinate and husbands to feign productivity, suggesting that women do not have the luxury to engage in either because they are too busy doing working that needs to get done. As such, although Walter’s view of gender relations is rather traditional, he acknowledges the unreasonably high expectations society places on women and the important work that women do to maintain the home.

Chapter 25: The Average Jane Quotes

☞ “It is my experience that far too many people do not appreciate the work and sacrifice that goes into being a wife, a mother, a woman. Well, I am not one of them. At the end of our thirty minutes together, we will have done something worth doing. We will have created something that will not go unnoticed. We will have made supper. And it will matter.”

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 217

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the first broadcast of *Supper at Six*, as Elizabeth speaks directly to her female viewers for the first time. Elizabeth acknowledges the significant sacrifices that women make, which broader society frequently overlooks. By stating that “we will have done something worth doing,” Elizabeth emphasizes the importance and value of the tasks women perform, which in this context refers to the domestic task of making supper. Elizabeth’s speech reimagines a routine, overlooked task as a creative and meaningful endeavor. She makes a statement about the importance of celebrating the daily contributions of women in the household, which contribute to the well-being and sustenance of the family. Elizabeth’s speech challenges her society’s dismissal of the domestic sphere as trivial or insignificant. It is a call to acknowledge the value of what is often considered mundane work and to see it as deserving of respect and appreciation.

Chapter 27: All About Me Quotes

☞ Harriet thought it was wrong not to believe in God. It lacked humility. In her opinion, believing in God was required, like brushing teeth or wearing underwear. Certainly, all decent people believed in God—even indecent people, like her husband, believed in God. God is why they were still married and why their marriage was her burden to bear—because it was given to her by God. God was big on burdens, and He made sure everyone got one. Besides, if you didn’t believe in God, you also didn’t get to believe in heaven or hell, and she very much wanted to believe in hell because she very much wanted to believe that Mr. Sloane was going there.

Related Characters: Harriet Sloane, Mr. Sloane

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 233

Explanation and Analysis

This excerpt captures Harriet’s perspective on faith and the role of God in her life. Harriet equates belief in God to essential daily practices like brushing teeth or wearing underwear, suggesting that for her, spirituality is a fundamental part of being a decent person. She holds the view that even those who are not morally upright, like her husband, believe in God. This belief system appears to give her a framework for enduring the difficulties in her marriage, viewing them as divinely ordained burdens that she must bear. Harriet’s reflections also touch on the concept of divine justice, with the mention of heaven and hell. Her desire to believe in hell is tied to her wish for retribution against Mr. Sloane, whom she believes deserves punishment. Of course, there is a great irony here. Although Harriet does not believe it is appropriate to divorce her husband, she does not see a problem with hoping he burns in hell for eternity. More critically, she fails to see her husband’s poor behavior as evidence that a belief in God doesn’t make a person a “decent” person—to the contrary, it shows that there is no link between being a decent person and believing in God. This is one passage in which the novel suggests the harm that can come from religion, blinding people to the ways in which religion perpetuates and justifies suffering in people’s lives—and makes people blind to that suffering.

Chapter 28: Saints Quotes

☞ He sighed inwardly. The problem with being a minister was how many times a day he had to lie. This was because people needed constant reassurance that things were okay or were going to be okay instead of the more obvious reality that things were bad and were only going to get worse. He’d been officiating a funeral just last week—one of his congregants had died of lung cancer—and his message to the family, all of whom also smoked like chimneys, was that the man had died, not because of his four-pack-a-day habit, but because God needed him. The family, each inhaling deeply, thanked him for his wisdom.

Related Characters: Wakely

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 243

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Reverend Wakely reflects on the nature of

his job and his own belief in a high power. He struggles with the ethical dilemma of providing reassurance to his congregation, telling them what they want to hear rather than what he believes to be true. Wakely's choice to comfort the family with a gentle untruth rather than addressing the dangerous behavior that likely led to their loved one's death reveals his difficult role as a spiritual guide. Notably, Wakely actually the man died because of cigarettes, which can be explained by science. However, it is not Wakely's role to say so: he is expected to provide solace and meaning in the face of tragedy, which sometimes leads him to sidestep uncomfortable realities. His internal sigh reveals his weariness with this aspect of his duties, indicating a sense of resignation to the expectations others place upon him. The family's acceptance of his words—and their ignorance about their own harmful habits—underscores the human tendency to avoid confronting difficult truths, especially when faced with grief and loss. It also suggests that religion exploits that tendency. From the way Wakely talks here and elsewhere, this tendency to avoid hard truths is common among those who come to see him.

Chapter 29: Bonding Quotes

☞ “Boys, set the table,” Elizabeth commanded. “Your mother needs a moment to herself.”

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Harriet Sloane

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 261

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is Elizabeth's catch phrase, which she uses to sign off at the end of every *Supper at Six* show. The sign off is notable for a few reasons. First, it is a reflection and slight alteration of the advice that Harriet gave Elizabeth when Harriet found her passed out in her home. However, rather than tell women to take time for themselves, Elizabeth commands the boys of the house to give their mother a break. In other words, she is asking men to step up and help out women, rather than letting women fend for themselves. This is the second and more significant aspect of the quote, as Elizabeth is advocating for a subversion of social norms that was considered radical in her time. Elizabeth's show starts in the early 1960s, before second-wave feminism has really begun to sweep the nation. As such, her catchphrase becomes a radical message of female empowerment, especially given that Elizabeth issues it in a commanding

tone.

Chapter 30: 99 Percent Quotes

☞ “No, Mad,” Elizabeth said. “The person who wants to interview me isn't even a science reporter; he writes for the women's page. He's already told me he has no interest in talking about chemistry, just dinner. Clearly, he doesn't understand you can't separate the two. And I suspect he also wants to ask questions about our family, even though our family is none of his business.”

“Why not?” Madeline asked. “What's wrong with our family?”

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Madeline Zott (speaker), Calvin Evans

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 263

Explanation and Analysis

This dialogue comes from the beginning of Chapter 30, as Elizabeth expresses frustration with the narrow perspective of a reporter who fails to see the connection between her work in chemistry and the act of preparing dinner. Her statement underscores the broader point that women's traditional responsibilities in the home do not allow them to be seen in a different light—whether that be as a professional scientist or something else altogether. Elizabeth's assertion of an inseparable link between cooking and science challenges society's tendency to elevate typically masculine profession of science but diminish the importance of typically feminine work of domestic labor. Meanwhile, Madeline's innocent question (“What's wrong with our family?”) reveals that she knows there is something about their family that Elizabeth is not telling her. Although Madeline's perspective is limited, she is an exceptionally perceptive child, and Elizabeth will not be able to hold on to her secrets forever. Someday, she will have to have the conversation with Madeline about her family that she never wanted to have with Calvin.

☞ “In contrast, *Supper at Six* focuses on our commonalities—our chemistries. So even though our viewers may find themselves locked into a learned societal behavior—say, the old ‘men are like this, women are like that’ type of thing—the show encourages them to think beyond that cultural simplicity. To think sensibly. Like a scientist.”

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Dr. Donatti, Phil Lebensmal

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 273

Explanation and Analysis

This moment comes from the meeting Elizabeth has with Phil Lebensmal regarding *Supper at Six*. Throughout the meeting, Lebensmal screams at Elizabeth and treats her horribly. However, Elizabeth continues to explain what she sees as the virtues of the show. In particular, she believes the show emphasizes shared human experience and can therefore bridge divides when it comes to gender roles. To Elizabeth, being a woman is only an important marker of identity because society tells her it is. Really, she is more interested in being a scientist and wants to encourage other women to be scientists, too, a prospect that sounds horrid to men like Lebensmal and Dr. Donatti. Although Elizabeth means well and expresses her genuine vision for the show, she could not have a worse audience. Lebensmal does not care about science—in fact, he actively ignores the data he receives telling him that *Supper at Six* is doing well—nor does he care about women’s empowerment. Still, Elizabeth tries to convince him because she believes it is important that her vision for the show be realized.

knows he has put up with Lebensmal’s terrible behavior for far too long. Here, Walter experiences a mix of validation and distress upon realizing that others share his hatred for Lebensmal. This awareness is validating because it confirms his feelings are not isolated, but it’s also “gut-wrenching” because it brings to light the consequences of his actions as someone who enforced policies that may have been harmful to others. The act of writing “MAY YOU NEVER RECOVER” on a card is symbolic, a physical manifestation of his internal conflict and desire for change. Walter does not want Lebensmal to recover because he wants to start a new era at the television station without Lebensmal’s corruptive influence. The message is also Walter’s small way of finally being able to stand up to his old boss and tell him how he really feels.

Chapter 37: Sold Out Quotes

💬 “As for Calvin’s death,” she said, “I’m one hundred percent responsible.” He paled as she went on to describe the accident and the leash and the sirens, and how because of it, she would never hold anyone back in any way, ever again. As she saw it, his death spawned a series of other failures: blindsided by Donatti’s theft, she’d given up her research; determined to help her daughter fit in, she’d enrolled her in a school where she did not; worse, she’d become the very person she least wanted to be, a performer like her father.

Chapter 31: The Get-Well Card Quotes

💬 Even though he knew he couldn’t possibly be the only one who’d hated the boss, he’d had no idea what a large club he belonged to. It was validating, sure, but also gut-wrenching. Because as a producer, he was part of Phil’s management team, and that meant he was responsible for pushing Phil’s agenda while ignoring those who ultimately paid the price for it. He reached for a pen and, for the fourth time that day, followed Elizabeth Zott’s simple advice: do what was right.

MAY YOU NEVER RECOVER, he wrote in huge letters across the middle. Then he stuffed the card in an enormous envelope, put it in the out basket, and made a solemn promise. Things had to change. He would start with himself.

Related Characters: Walter Pine, Phil Lebensmal

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 281-282

Explanation and Analysis

The passage reflects a moment of reckoning for Walter, who

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Calvin Evans, Dr. Donatti, Elizabeth’s Father, Franklin Roth

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 333-334

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from Elizabeth Zott’s interview with Franklin Roth, a prize-winning interviewer whom she has decided to open up to. Here, Elizabeth grapples with her feelings of guilt surrounding Calvin’s death. She takes full responsibility for the events that led to his death, a burden that has clearly weighed on her. The description of the accident with the leash and sirens paints a vivid picture of a traumatic moment, marking a turning point in her life. Elizabeth’s confession not only highlights her own sense of culpability but also sets the stage for her personal transformation. The event has caused her to vow never to hold anyone back again, a promise that stems from her deep regret and the consequences of her actions. Her reflection on the subsequent “failures” illustrates how the accident has rippled through her life, affecting her decisions and self-

perception. She views her life since Calvin's death as reactionary rather than as a reflection of her true self.

Chapter 38: Brownies Quotes

☝☝ "Listen to me, Mad," Elizabeth said. "Very closely. I'm still a chemist. A chemist on television."

"No," Mad said sadly. "You're not."

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Madeline Zott (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 345

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from the end of Chapter 38, Elizabeth tries to assert her identity as a chemist to Madeline. Elizabeth's insistence on being "a chemist on television" suggests that she is trying to maintain her professional identity despite her decision to continue making *Supper at Six*. Madeline's response, expressed sadly, indicates a dissonance between how Elizabeth sees herself—or, at least, how she wishes Madeline would perceive her—and how Mad actually perceives her. From this conversation with Madeline, Elizabeth realizes that she has been fooling herself into thinking she is still a chemist, when no one else thinks of her that way due to the show's emphasis on her looks and personality over her abilities as a scientist. While it would not be an issue if Elizabeth did not mind her new position, Madeline can tell that her mother still wants to be a chemist and is disappointed that Elizabeth is not living her dream. Additionally, Madeline likely has a sense that Elizabeth took the job on *Supper at Six* to take care of her, which makes her feel guilty.

Chapter 39: Dear Sirs Quotes

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Madeline Zott

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 350

Explanation and Analysis

Having finished her daily lunch box notes to Madeline, Elizabeth closed the lid, then pretended to fuss with a Bunsen burner. For the last few weeks, she'd done her best

to keep her head up—ignore the article, she told herself. Carry on. That was the coping strategy that had carried her through suicide, sexual assault, lies, thievery, and catastrophic loss; it would again. Except it hadn't. This time, no matter how high she lifted her head, *Life's* misrepresentation of who she was beat her back down again. The damage felt permanent, like a brand. She would never outrun it.

This passage delves into Elizabeth's psychological state as she deals with a multitude of past and present traumas and tries to come to terms with what she is putting herself and Madeline through. Despite Elizabeth's resilience in the face of overwhelming adversity—suicide, sexual assault, lies, thievery, and loss—she finds herself struggling against the pervasive impact of how the media has misrepresented her identity. The image of *Life's* misrepresentation beating her down "again" implies a cyclical battle where each attempt to transcend her supposed social role gets met with resistance from those who want to keep her where they feel she belongs. The feeling of damage being permanent, "like a brand," is particularly evocative, suggesting a mark has been seared into her identity, visible and indelible. Elizabeth's conclusion that she cannot outrun the misrepresentation speaks to a deep sense of defeat. It also points to her fear that false narratives may forever obscure her true self from the public.

Chapter 40: Normal Quotes

☝☝ "You're a scientist," he said. "Your job is to question things—to search for answers. But sometimes—and I know this for a fact—there just aren't any."

Related Characters: Wakely (speaker), Elizabeth Zott

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 356

Explanation and Analysis

This is something Wakely says to Elizabeth as they are discussing the difficult and traumatic events they have experienced in their lives. Here, Wakely acknowledges Elizabeth's scientific approach and points out the essence of her profession, which is to question and seek answers. However, he also introduces a sobering and often difficult reality—that sometimes, despite one's best efforts, there are no clear answers to life's great challenges. This acknowledgment speaks to the limitations of human understanding and the inherent uncertainty in both science and life. It touches on the concept of acceptance, suggesting

that part of the human experience is coming to terms with the unknown. For a scientist like Elizabeth, who is driven by the desire to understand and explain, this can be a particularly challenging concept to grapple with. It is an important moment for Elizabeth that also reveals why Wakely is an effective reverend, even if he no longer believes in God.

Chapter 42: Personnel Quotes

☛ All eyes turned to Elizabeth, but she didn't seem to notice; she was already fixated on the sputtering Donatti. Hands on hips, she leaned forward slightly, her eyes narrowed as if peering into a microscope. There were two beats of silence. Then she leaned back as if she'd seen enough.

"Sorry, Donatti," she said, handing him a pen. "You're just not smart enough."

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott (speaker), Dr. Donatti

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 370

Explanation and Analysis

This is the final exchange between Elizabeth and her nemesis, Dr. Donatti, who has insisted on ruining her life whenever the opportunity arises. Earlier in the novel, Donatti told Elizabeth that she was not smart enough to do abiogenesis research, which was a complete falsehood. Here, Elizabeth weaponizes Donatti's words against him, though her statement actually rings true. Essentially, she is firing Donatti from Hastings because, in addition to being a terrible person, he is not smart enough to occupy the position he currently holds. The pen that Elizabeth hands Donatti is also significant. Throughout the novel, pencils are an important symbol for Elizabeth because they have the ability to erase and fix mistakes, which she believes is the epitome of science. Therefore, Elizabeth hands Donatti a

pen to imply that her decision is permanent and to suggest that he does not have a scientific mindset, despite what he might like to believe about his abilities.

Chapter 45: Supper at Six Quotes

☛ "Let's say supper at six, then," Elizabeth said, not wanting her to go. "The home lab. Everyone—you, Wilson, Mad, Sixty-Three, me, Harriet, Walter. You'll need to meet Wakely and Mason at some point, too. The whole family."

Avery Parker, her face suddenly familiar with Calvin's smile, turned back and took Elizabeth's hands in her own. "The whole family," she said.

Related Characters: Elizabeth Zott, Avery Parker (speaker), Walter Pine, Harriet Sloane, Madeline Zott, Six-Three, Wakely, Dr. Mason, Wilson

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 386

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Elizabeth invites Avery Parker to join her and others for supper, suggesting a gathering at her home. By listing the people who will be at supper, and by mentioning Wakely and Mason, she defines her concept of family as inclusive of a broader community beyond genetic heritage. In response, Avery's decision to take Elizabeth's hands is a gesture of acceptance and unity, reinforcing the idea of a chosen family bound together by shared experiences and affection rather than blood relations. This is an important moment for both Elizabeth and Avery, as they finally allow themselves to open up and accept someone new into their lives. Both women have struggled since Calvin's death, and this is the first time they have felt genuine happiness and a sense of acceptance in a long time. Additionally, these lines come just moments before the end of the novel, suggesting that the future of Elizabeth and her newfound family looks bright.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1: NOVEMBER 1961

In 1961, Elizabeth Zott lives in Southern California with her daughter Madeline. The women's movement is on the horizon but has not occurred yet, and most women have yet to join the workforce. However, Elizabeth is ahead of her time, and she regularly encourages Madeline to outperform her male classmates, regardless of the social cost. Elizabeth knows Madeline is special because she is reading Dickens at age five, putting her far ahead of her peers. However, Madeline does not want to stand out, so when she goes to school, she pretends to be less mature than she is. Every day after school, Madeline waits for Elizabeth to come home from her television show she hosts, *Supper at Six*.

The early 1960s was a time when second-wave feminism was emerging, yet the full force of this cultural shift was still on the horizon. In the context of the era, Elizabeth is portrayed as a progressive and somewhat anachronistic figure, challenging the norms that defined women's roles in society. Elizabeth's encouragement of her daughter to excel academically and to outperform male classmates is a direct challenge to the gender expectations of the time.



CHAPTER 2: PINE

Before Elizabeth Zott became the host of *Supper at Six*, she was a research chemist. She got the job as the host of *Supper at Six* after a strange confrontation with Walter Pine, a producer at the local television studio. Elizabeth paid a visit to Walter's office after discovering that his daughter Amanda was trading lunches with Madeline at school every day. Elizabeth puts a lot of time and effort into ensuring that her daughter has a nutritious and balanced lunch, and she says as much to Walter.

Elizabeth's professional background as a chemist is significant as it places her in a male-dominated field. The transition from chemist to television cooking show host during an era where women were often not seen in scientific roles is a drastic shift and speaks to the gender biases of the time. What is still unclear is why someone like Elizabeth would take such a role.



Walter is taken aback when Elizabeth enters his office. He does not know why she came or what she wants. For a moment, he wonders if she is attempting to audition for him. Eventually, Elizabeth clarifies that she is a research chemist, and she has come to ensure that Amanda eats her own lunch from now on. Walter, however, is too focused on Elizabeth's beauty to respond to her demands.

Walter's reaction to Elizabeth's unanticipated visit highlights the limited expectations society held for women and their perceived roles. His focus on her appearance rather than her concern about the children's lunches reveals the objectification Elizabeth experiences due to her gender.



Because of Elizabeth's concerns regarding nutrition, Walter offers her a cooking show on his network. Elizabeth accepts the job because it pays more than her research work, and she wants to ensure she can make ends meet for Madeline. Quickly, *Supper at Six* becomes one of the most popular shows in the country—even the president watches it. Journalists begin writing about Elizabeth, including one who nicknames her Luscious Lizzie, which quickly catches on with the public. Despite her success, Elizabeth feels ashamed of her job because she thinks she should aspire for more. On occasion, she lies in bed and thinks about a man named Calvin Evans, who she feels is responsible for the current trajectory of her life.

The success of "Supper at Six" suggests that Elizabeth has a significant impact on the cultural landscape. However, the nickname "Luscious Lizzie" implies that part of her popularity is due to objectification by men. The nickname suggests that Elizabeth's beauty is her most important quality, while the public ignores her intellect. Elizabeth perceives the cooking show as a step down from her research work, which reflects how women's work is often undervalued, regardless of its success or influence.



CHAPTER 3: HASTINGS RESEARCH INSTITUTE

Ten years earlier, in January of 1952, Elizabeth is working with Calvin Evans at the Hastings Research Institute. By all accounts, Calvin is a genius when it comes to chemistry, having already contributed significant research to the field in his early twenties. Other than chemistry, the only thing Calvin loves and excels at is rowing. However, Calvin struggles in other areas of life, especially dating.

Based on the end of the previous chapter, it is difficult to know whether Calvin will prove a positive or negative force in Elizabeth's life. At this point, Calvin fits the stereotype of a 1950s scientist. Though he is brilliant, his social skills are lacking, especially as they relate to women.



After studying at Cambridge, Calvin moves to Southern California and meets Elizabeth at the Hastings Research Institute, where they both work. One morning, Elizabeth enters Calvin's office because she needs to borrow some beakers. She ignores the signs on his door saying that the office is off limits and enters anyway. Calvin is annoyed when he sees Elizabeth in his office and assumes she is a secretary. He tells her that he will not give her any beakers unless her boss gives him a call. Annoyed, Elizabeth grabs a box of beakers and leaves.

Calvin's presumption that Elizabeth is a secretary rather than a fellow scientist ruins their first interaction and reflects the prevalent gender bias in the professional world at that time. Meanwhile, Elizabeth's decision to simply ignore the signs in his office suggests that she is unwilling to accept the status quo. She treats Calvin as she would anyone else, which in this case means taking his supplies whether he likes it or not.



A few weeks later, Calvin tracks down Elizabeth and apologizes for his behavior. He also asks her out on a date, but Elizabeth rejects him. After Calvin steps away, a lab tech asks Elizabeth why she is talking to him. Elizabeth explains the situation, which surprises the lab tech. The lab tech warns her that Calvin is famous for holding grudges. He suggests that Elizabeth apologize to Calvin, so a bigger problem does not arise. Elizabeth tells the lab tech not to worry about it and that everything will be fine.

The lab tech's warning about Calvin's tendency to hold grudges introduces an element of tension and potential conflict between Calvin and Elizabeth. Despite the advice to apologize to prevent further issues, Elizabeth's dismissive response indicates her self-assurance in handling such situations.



The next day, Elizabeth notices that her beakers are gone because someone else in her lab took it upon themselves to return them. For some time after this incident, Elizabeth regularly hears her fellow lab techs insulting her. In particular, she hears someone imply that she only got her degree because she traded sexual favors for it. She also hears her boss, Dr. Donatti, call her a “cunt,” which shocks her.

Elizabeth was called the same word once before, when she was working on her PhD at UCLA. One night, while she was alone doing work in a lab, the leader of her research team, Dr. Meyers, entered the room and chastised her for double-checking work he had already completed. Everyone on Meyers’s team hated him—he was rude, arrogant, and regularly took all the credit for the work of his graduate students. However, Elizabeth put up with him because she knew he had a good reputation in the broader scientific community, and she wanted to make a name for herself.

When Elizabeth politely tried to tell Meyers that she thought she found an error in his work, he locked the door behind him and then aggressively moved toward her. Then, he slapped her hard in the face and began ripping her clothes off. Elizabeth struggled, trying to get away from Meyers, but he was too strong. Meyers raped Elizabeth as she continued to fight. Annoyed with Elizabeth’s resistance, Meyers called her a “cunt.” Eventually, Elizabeth managed to grab a **pencil** and stab it into Meyers’s side. In doing so, she managed to pierce his large and small intestine.

After the sexual assault, a police officer interviewed Elizabeth but did not take anything she said seriously. The office suggested that Elizabeth make a statement of regret to make herself look better in the situation. Elizabeth responded that her only regret was not having more **pencils**. Following the assault, the admissions committee at UCLA rescinded her admittance to the doctoral program. She left UCLA with an MA and then went to work at the Hastings Research Institute.

Now, the lab tech at the Hastings Institute apologizes to Elizabeth for making such a big deal about the beakers and tells her to ignore the other men’s disparaging comments. However, Dr. Donatti reassigns her to a new research project the next day, which he says is “More [her] intellectual speed.” Elizabeth accepts the new position without complaint but is internally furious that she is being punished unfairly.

The negative reactions from Elizabeth’s colleagues and the disrespectful treatment she endures, including the theft of her beakers and the insults about her qualifications, highlight the sexism Elizabeth faces in her work environment. Dr. Donatti’s use of a derogatory term to describe Elizabeth is especially jarring, revealing the blatant disrespect and devaluation of her character.



Dr. Meyers gets angry with Elizabeth not because she is wrong, but because she dares to question him. Given that Dr. Meyers seems to take credit for the work of others—and given that Elizabeth is a great student—it seems likely she is right. However, she puts up with his abusive treatment because she thinks it is the only way for her to get ahead in the male-dominated field of chemistry.



Given Elizabeth’s experience with Meyers, Dr. Donatti’s insult certainly carries an extra bite, even though it would be terrible enough anyway. Although Elizabeth is a capable young woman, here she finds herself at the hands of someone who is physically stronger than her and manages to overpower her. Although Elizabeth manages to escape Meyers’s grasp, this is a moment of significant trauma that stays with her throughout her life.



No one in a position of authority is willing to defend Elizabeth, so she ends up getting kicked out of UCLA. For both the police and the admissions committee, the truth seems secondary to whomever holds the most power, which in this case is Dr. Meyers. As such, Meyers’s behavior not only results in lasting trauma for Elizabeth, but it also railroads her career.



The lab technician’s apology acknowledges the inappropriate behavior, yet it is superficial as the structural issue remains unaddressed. Meanwhile, Donatti’s words are a clear instance of sexism, implying that Elizabeth’s current work—which she completes with far more ease than her colleagues—is beyond her capabilities.



A few weeks later, Elizabeth goes to see an operetta, *The Mikado*, but decides to leave at intermission because she hates it. As luck would have it, Calvin is also there, on a date with a secretary from the Hastings Institute. Throughout the first half of the show, Calvin's stomach feels terrible. He stands up to leave at intermission, feeling like he is going to vomit. In the theatre's lobby, he accidentally bumps into Elizabeth, which is apparently too much for his stomach to take, because he vomits near (and partially on) Elizabeth. Elizabeth is shocked for a moment, but she quickly pulls herself together and asks if there is a doctor around. When no one comes to help, she offers to get Calvin a paper towel. It is only at that moment when she realizes that they already know each other.

Elizabeth helps Calvin home and makes sure he is okay. She tells him that he probably just has food poisoning. Calvin apologizes repeatedly for vomiting on Elizabeth's dress. Elizabeth tells him not to worry about it. He also apologizes again for assuming she was a secretary at work. To this, Elizabeth has no response.

One week later, Elizabeth and Calvin discuss Elizabeth's research interests over a cup of coffee. Elizabeth tells him that, prior to her recent assignment change, she was researching polyphosphoric acids. However, her real interest is in abiogenesis, the study of the origin of all life on earth. Calvin notes that abiogenesis is something only someone with a PhD would focus on and asks about Elizabeth's time in academia. Elizabeth vaguely explains that she did not finish her PhD but does not elaborate.

Calvin then asks why Elizabeth is no longer researching polyphosphoric acids, which he sees as a valuable area of study. Elizabeth responds that sexism is responsible. Calvin appears surprised by her response, which sparks a brief conversation about sexism in science. By the end of the conversation, Calvin sees Elizabeth's point and offers to help her. At first, Elizabeth balks at the idea of getting help from Calvin, but she quickly realizes that his help would be useful in allowing her to work on polyphosphoric acids again. She accepts his help but warns him that she will not date him, even though she secretly wants to.

The Mikado is a comic opera by Arthur Sullivan and W.S. Gilbert that satirized late nineteenth-century Britain. Although it received wide-spread acclaim at the time of its release, many contemporary scholars criticize it for its stereotypical characterizations of its Asian characters. Elizabeth's decision to leave The Mikado due to her dislike for it shows her assertiveness and refusal to conform to expectations for the sake of appearances. Meanwhile, Calvin's decision to leave the show is completely by chance and has nothing to do with how he feels about it.



Elizabeth's immediate shift from shock to assistance demonstrates her professionalism and empathy, traits that are not recognized in her work environment. She does not respond to Calvin's repeated apology, perhaps because she is still angry or perhaps because she is at a loss for words.



Elizabeth's disclosure about her research interests sheds light on her academic capabilities and ambitions. Meanwhile, Calvin's remark about abiogenesis being a topic for someone with a PhD inadvertently touches on sensitive issues surrounding Elizabeth's time at UCLA. Of course, Calvin has no idea about Elizabeth's assault and is not attempting to open old wounds.



Calvin's inquiry into why Elizabeth stopped her initial research opens the door to a discussion about sexism in the scientific community. Elizabeth's straightforward discussion of sexism reveals her awareness of the discriminatory practices that have affected her career. In sharp contrast, Calvin's surprise suggests a lack of awareness about such issues, likely because he has never faced discrimination in his young and successful career.



CHAPTER 4: INTRODUCTION TO CHEMISTRY

Three weeks later, Elizabeth and Calvin are standing in a parking lot, arguing about their research. Calvin had made a point over the last three weeks to treat Elizabeth just like he would anyone else. However, secretly, he is falling in love with her, and has a hard time focusing on the research at hand. Meanwhile, although Elizabeth appreciates Calvin's attempt to act professional, she thinks he tends to come off as rude. Still, she feels attracted to him and regularly gets the urge to kiss him. Finally, while standing in the parking lot, she decides to act on that urge and kisses Calvin as they are saying their goodbyes.

Even though she wishes she felt differently, Elizabeth's private desires ultimately supersede her wish to remain on professional terms with Calvin. Elizabeth and Calvin know this action could potentially change the dynamics of their relationship, for better or worse. However, they decide to take a leap of faith and trust that the other has their best interests in mind, both personally and professionally.



CHAPTER 5: FAMILY VALUES

Although Elizabeth and Calvin enjoy a happy and exciting first few months of their relationship, many of their co-workers think that Elizabeth only likes Calvin because he is famous. They make such assumptions without ever asking Elizabeth and Calvin how they really feel. If they did, they would learn that Elizabeth and Calvin truly love each other.

The assumption that Elizabeth's affection is linked to Calvin's fame is a critique of how society often reduces the complexity of women's agency, especially if they are in a relationship with a man of Calvin's fame and stature.



The only issue in Elizabeth and Calvin's relationship—other than the disrespect they receive from their peers—is that they have put off the subject of family. At first, they did not discuss the subject accidentally, but eventually it was on purpose because neither wanted to share their background with the other.

The subject of family, which Calvin and Elizabeth both deliberately avoid, represents a deeper layer of personal vulnerability that both characters are hesitant to expose to the other. It suggests that both Elizabeth and Calvin have past traumas that they are not yet ready to share, even with each other.



One day, just before Thanksgiving, Calvin works up the courage to ask Elizabeth if she will be going anywhere for the holidays. This turns into a larger conversation about their families. Calvin explains that he has no family to go to because a train hit and killed his parents when he was five. After, he went to live with his aunt, who also died in a freak accident a few years later. Finally, he ended up in a Catholic boys home, which he hated.

Calvin's history of displacement, with the tragic deaths of his parents and aunt, followed by an unhappy time in a boys home, paints a picture of a man who has faced significant adversity from a young age. He is one of several characters in the novel who grows up without knowing one or both of his parents.



Elizabeth explains that she also had a rough upbringing: Elizabeth's father was a religious charlatan who went around claiming the world was about to end. Then, he would capitalize on people's fear by selling them trinkets that he claimed would protect them. Elizabeth's mother aided her father, and so Elizabeth despises them both. She also had to move around a lot as a child because her father was constantly being run out of town.

Elizabeth's revelation about her father being a religious charlatan and her mother's complicity provides a background of disillusionment, explaining her distaste for deception and perhaps contributing to her desire for sincerity and scientific truth in her professional life. Throughout the book, she expresses distaste for religion, which likely originated from this part of her life.



Additionally, Elizabeth had a brother, John, who was gay. Elizabeth's parents tormented John because of his sexuality, which eventually drove him to suicide. Eventually, Elizabeth's parents abandoned her altogether—although she was practically raising herself before anyway—because Elizabeth's father was arrested for murdering three people when one of his “miracles” went wrong. Meanwhile, Elizabeth's mother fled the country to avoid being brought up on charges of tax evasion.

This aspect of Elizabeth's past not only explains her independence and resilience but also highlights the stigma surrounding homosexuality that was present at the time. Here and elsewhere, Elizabeth acts as a woman ahead of her time, though in reality, she is simply showing affection for someone she cares for—something her fraudster parents could never do.



Elizabeth and Calvin are both surprised by what the other has to say. However, neither presses the other to give information they are not comfortable with sharing. Instead, they go to sleep and decide they will talk about the topic another time, even though neither of them wants to.

This conversation demonstrates that an intimacy has developed between Elizabeth and Calvin, as sharing such painful memories is a significant step in their relationship. However, there are aspects of themselves that they still want to keep secret.



CHAPTER 6: THE HASTINGS CAFETERIA

Although Calvin and Elizabeth are happy together, it seems that everyone at Hastings is rooting for their relationship to fail. They gossip nonstop about them, and the gossip is neither fair nor truthful. The worst gossip of all is a woman named Miss Frask, who works as a secretary in Personnel. Her job grants her access to lots of information about everyone, and she enjoys spreading gossip whenever she can.

Miss Frask epitomizes the role of the office gossip, exploiting her access to personal information so she can insert herself into the lives of others and sow discord. Notably, Elizabeth has yet to interact with Miss Frask, so Miss Frask has no reason to dislike her. This also means Frask does not know anything about Elizabeth's life.



However, Elizabeth and Calvin have more pressing concerns other than what their peers think about them. For one, they decide to move in together. Elizabeth knows she cannot afford to pay the same amount of rent as Calvin, so she offers to cook for him five times a week in addition to what she can afford to pay. Calvin accepts the deal, knowing it is the only way he can get Elizabeth to come live with him.

The decision to move in together marks a significant step in Calvin and Elizabeth's relationship. Elizabeth's offer to cook to make up for what she can't contribute to rent illustrates her desire to maintain an equitable partnership.



Calvin also tries to get Elizabeth to come work with him in his lab, but she refuses. She does not want others to get the impression that she is only with Calvin to advance her career. Additionally, she does not want Calvin to get credit for her accomplishments. Calvin recently received his third Nobel Prize nomination, and Elizabeth knows she will always be in his shadow if she associates too closely with him.

Elizabeth's refusal to work in Calvin's lab underscores her desire to be valued for her own merits. Her concern about being overshadowed by Calvin, speaks to a broader societal trend where women's achievements can be overshadowed by their more prominent male partners.



Elizabeth and Calvin also discuss the topic of marriage, which Elizabeth is against. Calvin respects Elizabeth's position, but he secretly hopes she will change her mind. He even buys a ring, which he carries around in his pocket, waiting for the right moment. One day, while sitting in the cafeteria at Hastings, Elizabeth tells Calvin that she will be attending a wedding because someone asked her to be a bridesmaid. Seeing a good opportunity, Calvin pulls out the ring he bought and proposes to Elizabeth. Nearby, their colleagues observe the scene, waiting to see how it plays out.

Elizabeth immediately rejects Calvin. She tells him that she does not want to become "Mrs. Calvin Evans" because of what it will do to her career. Calvin says he does not care if she changes her last name to match his. However, for Elizabeth, that is not the point. She feels like people will view her as "Mrs. Calvin Evans" even if she retains her own last name. Elizabeth's rejection hurts Calvin and puts him in a bad mood.

Calvin asks Elizabeth if she will reconsider. He wants to start a family and thinks of marriage as the first step. This suggestion is even more appalling to Elizabeth, who was under the impression that Calvin had no interest in kids. Calvin tells Elizabeth that he wasn't thinking of kids—rather, he wants the two of them to get a dog. Relieved, Elizabeth kisses Calvin and says she would be happy to get a dog with him, though she still does not agree to marry him. Nearby, their Hastings colleagues are annoyed that things ended up going well.

CHAPTER 7: SIX-THIRTY

A month after Calvin suggests he and Elizabeth get a dog, one follows Elizabeth home from the grocery store. Elizabeth can tell the dog needs a home, so she decides to adopt him and give him the name "Six-Thirty" to align with the time she found him. Although Calvin and Elizabeth would have no way of knowing it, Six-Thirty was previously trained as a bomb-detection dog for the marines.

In training camp, Six-Thirty had no problem detecting bombs, but rather than going toward them like he was supposed to, he would run away and hide. Annoyed, Six-Thirty's trainer abandoned him near a highway. He was on his own for a while before finding Elizabeth and Calvin. Elizabeth and Calvin fall in love with Six-Thirty and take him everywhere, including to Hastings. Dogs are not supposed to be on the premises of Hastings, but no one complains because the dog belongs to Calvin. However, secretly, many people are annoyed.

The conversation about marriage between Elizabeth and Calvin introduces the theme of personal values versus societal expectations. Elizabeth's opposition to marriage is indicative of her desire to maintain her professional identity and autonomy. Meanwhile, Calvin's secret hope and the act of carrying a ring shows a traditional romantic idealism that is in tension with Elizabeth's modern independence.



The public proposal in the cafeteria is a critical moment where private desires clash with public spectacle. Elizabeth's rejection is not just about refusing Calvin; it's a statement against being sucked into the identity of "Mrs. Calvin Evans," which she fears would diminish her personal agency and sense of self.



When Calvin reveals that he was not referring to children but rather getting a dog together, it alleviates Elizabeth's concerns and allows for them to compromise on their future together. However, whether the suggestion was actually Calvin's plan from the start—as opposed to suggesting they have children together—is unclear.



The addition of Six-Thirty to the lives of Elizabeth and Calvin introduces an element of serendipity to the narrative. Like Elizabeth and Calvin, Six-Thirty needed someone to adopt and take care of him. Calvin and Elizabeth plan to care for Six-Thirty in a way that their parents never cared for them.



Six-Thirty being welcomed at Hastings primarily because of Calvin's status once again touches on the theme of workplace dynamics and favoritism. Although Elizabeth and Calvin's colleagues are often cruel and unreasonable, the origin of their behavior is that they cannot stand that Calvin gets to do whatever he wants. Once again, it seems that Calvin gets to break the rules simply because he is famous (and it also doesn't hurt that he's a man).



After work, Elizabeth spends her evenings cooking meals. To her, cooking is chemistry and therefore of interest and value—it's not just some kind of "feminine duty." She spends a lot of time making sure the meals she creates are nutritionally balanced and treats them like experiments more than anything else.

One day, Calvin asks Elizabeth to come rowing with him. At first, Elizabeth balks at the idea and even suggests that rowing is for men, not women. However, Calvin quickly notes her hypocrisy and convinces her to come rowing with him. Before actually getting into a boat, Calvin has Elizabeth practice on a rowing machine (or "erg"), so she can get used to the motion. Although Elizabeth still has reservations about getting into rowing, Calvin tells other men at the rowing club that she is his new partner. They all look at him with astonishment, assuming that Elizabeth must be a talented rower. Their reactions suggest to Elizabeth that Calvin must be an excellent rower in addition to being an amazing scientist.

CHAPTER 8: OVERREACHING

The first few times Elizabeth and Calvin row together, Elizabeth feels overwhelmed and annoyed. She can never get the movements right and even causes their boat to flip a few times. No matter what she does, it seems as though Calvin is asking her to do something else. At the end of a particularly frustrating session, Calvin suggests that she think of rowing in terms of the physics that dictate it. Elizabeth takes his suggestion to heart and reads about the physics of rowing. Then, the next time they row together, she performs flawlessly because she understands the physics governing the sport.

Meanwhile, Elizabeth continues to have a hard time at Hastings. She wants to work on abiogenesis, but Donatti will not let her because he does not think she is smart enough. While speaking to Elizabeth, Donatti sees bandages on her hands and realizes that she has been rowing with Calvin. The bandages make Donatti think back to the first time he met Calvin. Calvin rowed against him in college and beat him. After the race, Donatti and Calvin shook hands, and Calvin acted disgusted when he saw that Donatti was drunk. From that day forward, Donatti hated Calvin, and his rage only increased when Calvin became famous in the scientific community.

As much as Donatti hates Calvin, he dislikes Elizabeth even more because she is a smart and opinionated woman. He does not necessarily doubt that Elizabeth has the intelligence to work on abiogenesis, but he refuses to let her because she does not align with his idea of what a woman should be.

Elizabeth's approach to cooking as chemistry is an assertion of her identity as a scientist, even in the domestic sphere. This perspective challenges the traditional notion of cooking as a "feminine duty" and instead frames it as an intellectual and creative pursuit.



Elizabeth's initial hesitation towards rowing and her assertion that it is for men challenges her own principles against gender stereotypes, reflecting an internal conflict where her progressive views clash with ingrained social norms. Calvin's playful accusation of hypocrisy serves as a challenge to Elizabeth, prompting her to reconsider her stance and join him in an activity that is traditionally seen as masculine. Rowing brings out a new side of Calvin, who otherwise seems bookish and socially awkward.



Calvin's advice to approach rowing from a scientific perspective—to think about the physics behind it—illustrates how different frameworks of understanding can help one improve one's performance. This moment signifies a turning point where Elizabeth bypasses her initial reservations and shows that her intellect can help her overcome physical barriers in addition to mental ones.



Elizabeth's professional struggles at Hastings underscore the theme of gender bias and in the workplace. Dr. Donatti's refusal to allow her to work on abiogenesis is another barrier he has erected for Elizabeth based on his underestimation of her capabilities rather than her actual potential or achievements. Additionally, his personal animosity toward Calvin reveals a deeper layer of professional jealousy that impacts his judgment of Elizabeth's work.



Despite recognizing Elizabeth's intelligence, Donatti allows his prejudice to dictate her opportunities. Notably, his prejudice is a problem not only for Elizabeth, but for the entire lab, as he is not getting the best work out of one of his best employees.



Elizabeth walks away angry after her discussion with Donatti and runs into Dr. Boryweitz, one of her lab mates. Boryweitz, who Elizabeth finds to be an awkward but kind man, asks Elizabeth a question about his research. Elizabeth supplies him with the answer he is looking for. Such an occurrence is far from rare; Elizabeth's colleagues often come to her for help when they think others are not paying attention.

Although Elizabeth repeatedly tells him not to, Calvin goes to speak with Donatti about Elizabeth's research a few days later. Calvin warns Donatti that he will walk away from Hastings if Donatti refuses to let Elizabeth do work that they both know she is qualified to do. While Donatti would like nothing more than for Calvin to leave Hastings, his hands are tied. Recently, a large donor sent Hastings a lot of money that they demanded be put toward abiogenesis research. Donatti knows that funding Elizabeth's research is the best answer to his problems, so he ultimately gives in. Elizabeth is overjoyed when she hears the news, though she is wary that Calvin might have influenced the decision. She asks Calvin to tell her the truth, but Calvin lies and says he had nothing to do with it.

Shortly after Elizabeth resumes her abiogenesis research, Calvin talks to Dr. Mason, the captain of the rowing team at their local boathouse. He knows there are openings on Dr. Mason's boat and wants to know if he and Elizabeth can join his team. Dr. Mason feels unsure about letting Elizabeth join but trusts Calvin's judgment enough to let it happen. When Elizabeth finds out what Calvin has done, she worries that she will not live up to the expectations he has set. However, Calvin assures her that she will do great and should not worry. Additionally, Elizabeth asks Calvin why everyone likes to say he holds grudges. Calvin reminds her that everyone at Hastings like to gossip and that almost nothing they say is true, including what they say about his propensity for holding grudges.

CHAPTER 9: THE GRUDGE

Although Calvin is not one to hold grudges, there is one person whom Calvin does hold a grudge against and whom he has not told Elizabeth about. When Calvin was 10 and living in the Catholic boys home, a well-dressed man visited and gave the home a lot of money. The bishop who ran the home used the money to buy educational materials relating to science and mathematics at the behest of the man who donated the money.

Elizabeth's interaction with Dr. Boryweitz offers a counterpoint to her experiences with Donatti. It highlights her reputation as a knowledgeable and helpful colleague, even if her assistance is sought out in private.



Calvin's intervention on Elizabeth's behalf is a well-intentioned but questionable act. His ultimatum to Donatti demonstrates the struggle to balance personal advocacy with respect for Elizabeth's autonomy. While his actions come from a good place, they also risk reinforcing the dynamics Elizabeth is fighting against: that is, the idea that, as a woman, her opportunities should come through male intervention rather than her own merits. Calvin knows that Elizabeth would be unhappy with his decision, which is why he chooses to lie to her when asked.



Dr. Mason's hesitation about Elizabeth's participation is superseded by his trust in Calvin. This highlights the degree to which personal endorsements influence the opportunities a person gets. It also hints at potential gender biases that exist in male-dominated activities like rowing. Meanwhile, Elizabeth's concern about meeting the expectations Calvin has set illustrates a common fear of not living up to one's potential, especially when entering a new, male-dominated space like the world of rowing.



Here, the secrets Calvin chose not to divulge to Elizabeth in Chapter 5 begin to come to the forefront of the narrative. This moment marks the beginning of one of the novel's most notable themes: the conflict between science and religion, a topic Elizabeth and Calvin feels particularly animated about because of how religious figures—or people claiming to be religious figures—negatively impacted their childhoods.



When Calvin asked the bishop about the educational materials, the bishop told him that the donor was Calvin's father, who demanded that the home be stocked with items relating to math and science. Calvin does not understand what the bishop is saying because he thought his father was dead. The bishop tells him that the parents he knew—the ones who died in an accident—are actually his adoptive parents.

The bishop's decision to use the money for educational materials in math and science could be seen as a catalyst for Calvin's later success in those fields, but it also brings to light the painful truth about his family. The mixture of philanthropy and personal rejection creates a conflict within Calvin, driving his passion for science while also leaving him with a sense of abandonment.



When Calvin questions him further, the bishop shows him his birth certificate, which has his real mother's name on it. According to the bishop, Calvin's real mother died while giving birth to him. Additionally, the bishop says that Calvin's father does not want to adopt him and plans to continue making donations to the boys home instead. At first, Calvin held out hope that his father would return to him. However, the longer he stayed in the boys home, the more he began to hate his father.

Calvin's initial hope that his father would return, followed by growing resentment, captures the emotional turmoil that accompanies abandonment and the longing for familial connections. His decision to keep this grudge secret from Elizabeth suggests that he has not fully processed what happened to him at the boys home.



CHAPTER 10: THE LEASH

Calvin opens a letter from a woman who claims she is his mother—it is the second such letter he has received in a short period of time. Calvin assumes the letter is fake because people often attempt to attach themselves to him due to his fame. He thinks about how it is ironic that strangers write to him, but his birth father never does. Calvin never talks to anyone about his father and still has not broached the subject with Elizabeth.

Calvin's guardedness about his father indicates a deep-seated pain, which he fears could ruin his relationship with Elizabeth. His silence is an attempt to protect himself, but it seems unlikely that he will be able to keep quiet on the subject forever, given how important it is to his life.



The only person who knows about Calvin's biological father, other than those who ran the boys home, is Wakely, Calvin's old pen pal, whom he never met in person. In a letter, Calvin once told Wakely that he wished his father were dead. Calvin presumes the letter shocked Wakely because Wakely never wrote back. Calvin avoids the subject with Elizabeth because he doesn't want it to drive a wedge between them.

The reference to Wakely, reveals Calvin's long-standing struggle with his feelings toward his father. The intensity of his emotions, wishing his father dead, and the subsequent loss of contact with Wakely demonstrates the profound impact his father's rejection has had on him.



Calvin also thinks about the city's new leash law. He and Elizabeth recently argued over whether they should start putting Six-Thirty on a leash. Calvin thinks he will be fine without one, but Elizabeth insists that they should follow the rules and avoid getting themselves or Six-Thirty in trouble. Previously, neither felt the need to leash Six-Thirty because he was so well trained and intelligent that he did not seem to need a leash. Eventually, Calvin gives in and starts putting a leash on Six-Thirty. If nothing else, he appreciates Elizabeth's maternal instincts. One day, shortly after Calvin starts putting a leash on Six-Thirty, he decides to run to work with Six-Thirty by his side. However, he never makes it to work because he dies on the way there, 37 minutes after departing from the house.

Calvin's eventual acquiescence to Elizabeth's insistence on following the leash law highlights his respect for her judgment and a recognition of her care and concern, which he likens to maternal instincts. Unfortunately, Calvin's decision to give into Elizabeth leads to his shocking death, which is surprising not just because of its suddenness but also because it leaves unresolved the threads of Calvin's history with his father, his relationship with Elizabeth, and the life he and Elizabeth were building together. It is a moment that subverts the standard plot of the romance novel and moves the story in a new direction.



CHAPTER 11: BUDGET CUTS

During their jog, Calvin and Six-Thirty pass the police station. As they pass the station, several police cars that are in poor shape backfire, startling Six-Thirty. Six-Thirty, frightened, jerks the leash in the opposite direction from Calvin. Calvin tries to maintain his balance, but instead slips on some motor oil and falls hard against the ground. The fall splits his skull. Moments later a police car backs over him because he is laying where they cannot see him.

When the police realize what they have done, they get out of the car and try to help Calvin. Nearby, Six-Thirty looks on and can tell that Calvin is close to death. Before long, an ambulance shows up, but it is already too late. Realizing nothing can be done, Six-Thirty walks home and prepares to comfort Elizabeth.

Here, the narrative backs up slightly to elaborate on the shocking events revealed at the end of the previous chapter. Despite the novel's ideological adherence to scientific principles, its plot often relies on coincidence and fate to progress. Calvin's death serves as the catalyst for everything that happens in the novel moving forward.



Here, Six-Thirty demonstrates that—even though he is a dog—he is more perceptive than many of the humans around him. In addition to his awareness of Calvin's death, he also recognizes that Elizabeth will soon need him more than ever.



CHAPTER 12: CALVIN'S PARTING GIFT

Elizabeth is distraught when she learns about what happened to Calvin. She feels responsible for his death because she asked him to start using a leash with Six-Thirty. When Elizabeth arrives at Calvin's funeral, she and Six-Thirty stand far away from the crowd, which is full of grieving rowers and scientists who have come to pay their respects.

A reporter spots Elizabeth and begins asking her questions about Calvin. The reporter does not realize who Elizabeth is and speaks rather casually. Elizabeth does nothing to correct him and, in fact, purposely leads him to believe that Calvin was simply an acquaintance. She also tells the reporter she is blind when he objects to her having a dog in the graveyard. Then, when the funeral starts to get underway, she walks away from the reporter to join everyone else.

The following day, Elizabeth goes to work, where Donatti promises to support her any way he can. However, neither he nor the other employees do anything else to comfort Elizabeth—in fact, they purposely ignore her. Elizabeth walks to Calvin's lab and is shocked to find that everything has already been cleaned and packed away. She looks in a box of Calvin's personal belongings and sees the ring he intended to give her.

Although Elizabeth cannot help but blame herself, there is no way she could know that leashing Six-Thirty would lead to Calvin's sudden and shocking death. Her decision to stand away from the crowd at Calvin's funeral is an expression of her guilt.



Because Elizabeth and Calvin never married, most people outside of Hastings do not know that they were a couple. Elizabeth has no desire to speak with the reporter, who she thinks has an unfair view of Calvin, and so she tells an obvious lie, knowing that the reporter will soon discover that she is not blind.



As usual, Donatti's actions fail to live up to his words. Although he claims he will be supportive, his track record suggests that he will not follow through on that promise. Meanwhile, the ring Elizabeth finds reminds her of the importance of her relationship with Calvin, even if they did not express their love for each other through the traditional means of marriage.



As Elizabeth looks at the ring and thinks about everything she has lost, Frask enters the lab. She sees Elizabeth going through Calvin's things and warns her that she is not allowed to touch them. Her language makes it obvious that she does not approve of Elizabeth and Calvin's relationship. Additionally, Frask spots Six-Thirty and warns Elizabeth that she cannot bring him to Hastings anymore. Frask says that Six-Thirty was only tolerated because of Calvin, and Elizabeth will no longer be able to hide behind Calvin for protection.

Frask also hands Elizabeth an article written by the reporter she met at Calvin's funeral. The article is unflattering toward both Elizabeth and Calvin. As she reads the article, Elizabeth begins feeling physically ill. She turns away and vomits, assuming the reaction is part of the grieving process. However, when she voices this opinion, Frask tells her she is naïve and that she is ill because she is pregnant.

Here, Frask is particularly cruel to Elizabeth. She does not even attempt to fake that she is sad for Elizabeth, as Donatti and other members of Hastings did. Rather, she is direct in his distaste for Elizabeth and vocalizes the opinions of the rest of the office. Now that Calvin is gone, Frask sees no reason to play nice with Elizabeth, even while she is still grieving.



The article shows how the media can distort truth, particularly when a reporter has a bias against the subject they are reporting on. Meanwhile, if Frask is correct about Elizabeth's condition, it appears that Elizabeth is about to face the one role she has always pushed back against: motherhood.



CHAPTER 13: IDIOTS

Calvin's passing and the publication of the disparaging article create a dilemma for Hastings because their chief donors threaten to pull funding, including the man who was funding the abiogenesis research. Now that Calvin is gone, Elizabeth is the only person who stands out as exceptionally talented at Hastings. Yet, due to her gender, Donatti is reluctant to grant her significant authority or opportunities. Additionally, he tells the abiogenesis donor that "Mr. Zott" is their chief researcher on the subject.

The situation becomes more complex when Elizabeth's pregnancy becomes public knowledge, thanks to Miss Frask, who gossips to everyone about what she has learned. Donatti worries that his investor will pull funding if he finds out Elizabeth is a woman. As such, even though Donatti does not have anyone else to work on abiogenesis, he fires Elizabeth. When Elizabeth contests her dismissal on the grounds of her pregnancy, she learns that Calvin's influence was the sole reason she had been allowed to pursue her abiogenesis research at all.

Even though he was compensated poorly, Calvin was the only person holding up the Hastings Institute. Although Elizabeth is also talented, without Calvin in the picture, her opportunities are limited, and Donatti knows he cannot use her as the face of the institution, nor would he. He assumes his investors would pull their funds if they discovered "Mr. Zott" was actually "Mrs. Zott."



Donatti's decision to fire Elizabeth comes from a mixture of his professional and personal concerns. He has been wanting to get rid of Elizabeth for a long time, but he has not found the proper grounds for termination. Because there were no laws in place to protect pregnant women against workplace discrimination in the 1960s, Donatti sees it as the perfect opportunity to get rid of Elizabeth.



CHAPTER 14: GRIEF

Six-Thirty visits Calvin's gravesite and studies the inscription on his tombstone. Elizabeth has been teaching Six-Thirty English to disprove Calvin's belief that dogs can only learn a set number of words. Already knowledgeable in over 100 words, Six-Thirty continues to learn under Elizabeth's guidance. Additionally, Six-Thirty has developed a unique way of silently communicating with Elizabeth's unborn child, whom he talks to about Calvin's death.

Six-Thirty is an outlier in the novel because his presence places the novel in the territory of magical realism. Although Garmus explains his ability to communicate through Elizabeth's lessons, Six-Thirty's cognitive capabilities far surpass those of a dog. In this section and elsewhere, Six-Thirty thinks through complex problems and emotions.



Three months after Calvin's death, Elizabeth transforms her kitchen into a laboratory. Luckily, Calvin included her on the deed for his apartment, so she was able to keep it after he died. Elizabeth did not know Calvin had done this for her until he had passed away. Since Elizabeth's dismissal from Hastings, her former colleagues often stop by the apartment to ask her questions about their work, especially Dr. Boryweitz. At first, Elizabeth provides help for free, but eventually she starts charging them so she can continue to afford the apartment.

During one of his trips to the cemetery, Six-Thirty speaks to Calvin's gravestone. Six-Thirty conveys updates about Elizabeth's new lab, her ongoing efforts to teach him words, and her persistence in her scientific pursuits. He also tells Calvin that he hopes Elizabeth's child will bring her happiness, which she desperately needs.

As Six-Thirty speaks to Calvin, the cemetery groundskeeper attempts to shoot him. Six-Thirty deftly evades the man and accidentally causes him to fall and injure his head. Recalling Calvin's accident, Six-Thirty acts swiftly to stop the bleeding from the groundskeeper's wound, barking to attract attention until help arrives. This incident catches the attention of the same reporter who wrote about Calvin, leading to a story about a loyal dog who both mourned his owner and saved a life. As a result, the groundskeeper loses his job, and the ban on dogs at the cemetery gets revoked.

CHAPTER 15: UNSOLICITED ADVICE

Elizabeth, now visibly pregnant, often receives unsolicited advice regarding her pregnancy from people she meets when she goes out. In particular, women like to tell her how difficult her life is going to become after she has her child. Frustrated, she decides to consult Dr. Mason, an obstetrician who also leads the rowing team.

Unlike everyone else, Dr. Mason treats Elizabeth's pregnancy with impartiality and professionalism. He empathizes with her and recognizes that motherhood might not be every woman's aspiration. He even subtly tells her that he approves of abortion, though it is not legal. This understanding approach deeply moves Elizabeth, marking the first time someone has shown her such empathy since Calvin's death.

The transformation of the kitchen into a lab suggests that Elizabeth wants her domestic space to be a workspace. Indeed, her house becomes her new workstation since she is no longer working at Hastings. Evidently, Elizabeth is missed at Hastings because her former colleagues—who showed her little to no appreciation previously—suddenly want her input on their work.



Again, Six-Thirty relays complex ideas and feelings that far surpass the cognitive functioning of dogs. Although he hopes that Elizabeth's child will bring her happiness, the attitudes Elizabeth expressed earlier in the narrative suggests that the opposite could be more likely.



Although a pariah at Hastings, here Six-Thirty becomes a valued and adored member of the community. As with the initial article about Calvin, this article discussing Six-Thirty heroic deeds draws attention to the power the media plays in day to day life. As the novel progresses, the power and influence of the media only grows.



Elizabeth does not want to be a mother and, based on the advice she gets from other people, it sounds like they don't want to be mothers either. Elizabeth already knows her life is going to be difficult following the birth of her child and does not need others to remind her.



Like Elizabeth, Dr. Mason's political attitudes are quite progressive for his time, which helps the two of them connect. Although their conversation is deeply personal, it also gestures toward a wider discussion about the treatment of women and their bodies.



Dr. Mason expresses both surprise and admiration when he learns that Elizabeth has continued using the rowing machine during her pregnancy. He believes this has been beneficial for her strength and health. Encouraged by her dedication, he invites her to rejoin the rowing team a year later, after she has given birth and recovered. He acknowledges Elizabeth's skill as a rower and reassures her that she will manage childbirth and recovery well.

Garmus implies that Elizabeth's persistent rowing is an attempt to get her body to miscarry. However, here Dr. Mason informs her that the opposite is true. Dr. Mason knows how Elizabeth feels about her situation and understands her. However, he is also careful to ensure that she is prepared for what is to come.



CHAPTER 16: LABOR

Five weeks later, following her consultation with Dr. Mason, Elizabeth and Six-Thirty head to the library to return books. Elizabeth believes she still has two weeks until her due date. However, Six-Thirty notices signs that Elizabeth's water has broken and interprets her complaints of hunger as pre-labor contractions. Near the library, Elizabeth experiences intense pain and realizes she needs to get to a hospital. Thirteen hours later, she gives birth to Madeline.

As always, Six-Thirty is by Elizabeth's side, making sure she is well taken care of. Madeline's birth is sudden and is not something that Garmus chooses to dwell on. Although pregnancy is obviously an important part of Elizabeth's life, Garmus elides the majority of that experience because she does not want it to define her protagonist.



Elizabeth leaves the hospital the next day with Madeline and returns to Six-Thirty, who eagerly awaits them at home. The reunion is filled with joy, and they momentarily feel like a complete family. However, this joyous atmosphere evaporates moments later when Madeline starts crying.

Despite Elizabeth's reluctance to have a child, Madeline's birth is a joyous moment for her. However, Madeline's cries serve as a reminder of how difficult motherhood will be—especially since she has to go through the process alone.



CHAPTER 17: HARRIET SLOANE

Elizabeth struggles with the relentless demands of caring for a newborn who constantly cries. She feels like she has an endless cycle of tasks, and she barely gets any sleep. During this exhausting period, Dr. Boryweitz stops by to offer a gift for the baby. He also asks for Elizabeth's assistance. Despite her exhaustion, Elizabeth agrees to help because she needs the money. However, she unintentionally falls asleep as soon as Boryweitz departs. She dreams about Calvin and is later woken up by her neighbor, Mrs. Harriet Sloane, who comes to check on her and the crying Madeline.

Because Calvin is dead, Elizabeth has to fulfill the roles of both mother and father by herself. However, because Donatti fired her, money is hard to come by, meaning she has to help Dr. Boryweitz, even if she can barely stay awake. Notably, even on very little sleep, Elizabeth is still more intellectually capable than her colleagues from the Hastings Institute, who come to ask her for help.



At first, Elizabeth does not recognize Harriet, as they have never spoken in public. However, Harriet quickly introduces herself and offers to help with Madeline. Then, Harriet skillfully calms and changes Madeline while expressing her sympathy to Elizabeth about her situation. Harriet then offers to make coffee but is taken aback by the sight of the lab equipment in the kitchen. Elizabeth steps in and uses the intricate lab equipment to make coffee, which turns out to be the best coffee Harriet has ever tasted.

Other than Six-Thirty, Calvin was the only important figure in Elizabeth's life, so much so that she had never met Harriet before. However, it seems that Harriet has been keeping an eye on Elizabeth and has experience with caring for children. Unlike Elizabeth, Harriet is used to playing a more traditionally feminine role, which is why the sight of Elizabeth's "kitchen" is especially surprising.



Harriet apologizes for not visiting sooner—she assumed Elizabeth already had help. Then, she offers her contact information for future assistance. Elizabeth is reluctant to take any help, but she accepts the number. Before Harriet leaves, Elizabeth admits that she thinks she is a terrible mother because she does not feel the way she thinks she is supposed to about her child. In fact, she has wanted to give Madeline away on multiple occasions. However, Harriet assures her that such feelings are normal and that motherhood is indeed exhausting and overwhelming. If anything, Harriet thinks Elizabeth is doing a great job, given her circumstances. Before leaving, Harriet advises Elizabeth to take time for herself every day to reconnect and reaffirm her passions and priorities.

Here, the novel delves into the complicated feelings that come with motherhood. Elizabeth fears that she is a bad parent because of how she feels about Madeline, presumably because of how she has heard other mothers discuss their children. Harriet's response indicates that much of the cultural discussion surrounding children and motherhood is disingenuous and that Elizabeth's feelings are perfectly normal. This is a relief to Elizabeth, who fears she will end up being a terrible parent to Madeline, just as her parents were for her.



CHAPTER 18: LEGALLY MAD

Harriet had been closely observing Elizabeth and Calvin's relationship from the start, albeit from the discrete distance of her window. At first, she was unsure that they would work together, as their relationship seemed unconventional. However, she quickly discovered they were a perfect match. In contrast, Harriet's own marriage is unhappy, with her husband, Mr. Sloane, being dull, ignorant, and vulgar.

Harriet spends a lot of time looking out her window because she does not like what she has at home. In Elizabeth and Calvin's relationship, she spotted something better than she has with her own husband. She wants to get away from her husband, but divorce is considered socially unacceptable (and it also had more legal restrictions at the time), and she has nowhere to go.



Elizabeth is still trying to cope with the demands of caring for Madeline. During this stressful time, she reflects on how Madeline got her name. In a moment of post-delivery exhaustion, Elizabeth misunderstood a nurse's question about the baby's name as a query about her own state of mind. Rather than give her child a name, she replied "Mad." Consequently, "Mad" was recorded on the birth certificate. However, the name "Madeline" comes to Elizabeth when Six-Thirty brings her a copy of *Remembrance of Things Past*, which mentions a madeleine cookie. Elizabeth likes the name but finds she can't officially change it due to bureaucratic hurdles requiring various documents, including a marriage certificate.

*Madeline's legal name demonstrates the lack of care and attention that Elizabeth receives following one of the most physical demanding and traumatic events of her life. The nurse who records Madeline's name as "Mad" is both emotionally and intellectually disengaged from the person she is supposed to be caring for. However, Elizabeth manages to find beauty in the name through its association to Proust's *Remembrance of Things Past*, which features a famous scene where the narrator eats a madeleine cookie that mentally transports him back to his childhood.*



After her initial meeting with Harriet, Elizabeth repeatedly considers calling her for help. It takes her four days to finally make the call. Harriet, who has been eagerly anticipating Elizabeth's call and monitoring her with binoculars, responds immediately and hurries over to help.

Elizabeth knows she needs help, but she is too stubborn to ask, especially from a woman who she barely knows. However, little does she know that Harriet is eager for any excuse to get away from her husband and is glad to come to Elizabeth's aid.



CHAPTER 19: DECEMBER 1956

Madeline's upbringing is a balance of exploration and safety: Elizabeth encourages her to experiment and discover her surroundings, and Harriet and Six-Thirty ensure that she stays out of danger. Gradually, Elizabeth and Madeline develop a deep bond, filled with mutual love and learning.

Because Madeline does not have a father, Harriet acts as her second parent. Elizabeth raises her daughter with a scientific mindset—experimentation is key, and failure is a necessary part of experimentation.



A year after Madeline's birth, Dr. Mason follows through on his promise and visits to check on Elizabeth. He extends an invitation for her to join the rowing team again. Elizabeth is taken aback, citing her busy schedule, but Dr. Mason humorously points out that she couldn't be busy at 4:30 a.m., the team's rowing time. Surprisingly, Harriet agrees to babysit Madeline during these early hours, eager for a respite from her own troubled home life. The other rowers respond to Elizabeth's return to the rowing team with skepticism and coldness. However, Dr. Mason reassures her of her competence and encourages her to continue rowing with the team.

Unlike Elizabeth's colleagues, who offer words of support but never follow through, Dr. Mason comes through on his promise. However, his suggestion is that Elizabeth continue to push herself beyond where she is comfortable. Despite her situation, Elizabeth rises to the challenge and puts herself in an environment where she knows she is unlikely to feel welcome. Without Calvin to shield her, the rowing team appears especially hostile (with the exception of Dr. Mason).



CHAPTER 20: LIFE STORY

At four years old, Madeline is still too young for kindergarten, but Elizabeth puts her in school anyway because she needs to get back to work so she can make ends meet. Madeline, physically larger than most children her age, stands out because of her advanced abilities, especially when it comes to reading. Additionally, Madeline possesses a remarkable intuition when it comes to what other are thinking and feeling—even (and perhaps especially) adults.

Like Six-Thirty, Madeline's intellectual capabilities far exceed what anyone her age should be able to do. As such, if anything, she appears too advanced for kindergarten and will appear out of place. In this way, she takes after her mother, who regularly outperforms her peers.



Elizabeth decides to return to Hastings to seek employment. She meets with Donatti, who appears relieved to see her and agrees to rehire her. Although Elizabeth is happy to have her old job back, Harriet thinks she should not have returned to a workplace that mistreated her and Calvin. Although Elizabeth does not know it, Donatti only rehired her because he knows he needs to please the abiogenesis donor, who is expecting results. Previously, when Donatti asked his staff if any of them had progress to report on abiogenesis, only Boryweitz had anything to say. However, Donatti can tell Boryweitz had help from outside because he cannot articulate his findings. Eventually, Boryweitz admits that he got help from Elizabeth.

Without Elizabeth, Donatti has had very little to work with. The few employees who have produced high-quality research have only done so because they have been paying visits to Elizabeth. Of course, Donatti will never thank Elizabeth for the work she did, nor publicly acknowledge her efforts. However, Elizabeth does not care about Donatti and his ego because she has more important things to care about: her daughter. Still, without Calvin, Hastings is likely to be a hostile environment for Elizabeth.



CHAPTER 21: E.Z.

On her first day back to Hastings, Donatti gifts Elizabeth a lab coat with her initials ("E.Z.") sewn in. Previously, her lab coat read: "E. Zott." Her re-entry is met with laughter from her colleagues when she dons the coat. Donatti surprises her by requesting to see all her work on abiogenesis, leaving Elizabeth puzzled about how he knew of her research outside of Hastings. She suspects Boryweitz, whom she had previously caught snooping through her files, as the source of this information.

Donatti then addresses Elizabeth with the demeaning nickname "Luscious," and he informs her that her role will be as a lab tech rather than a chemist. Donatti also offers her a correspondence course in dictation before leaving for a meeting. Elizabeth is outraged because Donatti had previously promised Elizabeth her old position back. She does not think she can survive on the lower pay that comes with the lab tech job.

Elizabeth, infuriated, encounters Frask in the bathroom. Frask is frustrated about having to report to a recently hired young man instead of receiving a promotion herself. During their encounter, Frask accuses Elizabeth of pretending to be a man to get her research published. Elizabeth vehemently denies the accusation, and their exchange escalates into a heated argument. This confrontation leads to the revelation that both women left their PhD programs after their thesis directors sexually assaulted them.

The "E.Z." on Elizabeth's coat is a pun on "easy," which is meant to imply that Elizabeth is sexually promiscuous. If Elizabeth did not immediately understand the pun, her colleagues ill-disguised laughter quickly gave it away. Elizabeth's first interactions of the day suggest that Hastings is just as bad as ever, if not worse. Whether Elizabeth likes it or not, she is indelibly linked to Calvin, and he is not around to shield her.



Again, Donatti uses language that intends to demean Elizabeth and lower her status in the workplace. Donatti thinks he can get away with treating Elizabeth however he wants because he knows she needs the money. However, he is walking a delicate line, as the job has significantly lowered in value in Elizabeth's eyes.



This is a significant moment for both Frask and Elizabeth, as they discover that they are more alike than they previously realized. The fact that both women had the same experience in college demonstrates how tolerant their field is of the mistreatment of women, failing to hold men accountable for their crimes and punishing those men's female victims.



CHAPTER 22: THE PRESENT

On her first day at school, Madeline receives a note from her teacher, Mrs. Mudford, requesting a meeting with Elizabeth. After starting her job as a lab technician at Hastings, Elizabeth seeks more details about the abiogenesis investor from Frask, only to discover that there is little to no information available. A few days after Elizabeth's conversation with Frask in the bathroom, Frask reveals that her new boss is firing her because she refuses to lose weight. As an act of retaliation, Frask decides to leave Elizabeth all of Calvin's work, which was previously stored away. Frask and Elizabeth both know what they are doing is illegal, but neither cares.

The lack of detail surrounding the abiogenesis investor—which has been mentioned multiple times—builds intrigue, foreshadowing that the identity of the investor will be important to the development of the plot. Meanwhile, Frask's dilemma is an example of how less-qualified men pushed women out of their jobs. Frask's new boss demands that she gets skinnier because he believes her looks are her only important feature.



CHAPTER 23: KCTV STUDIOS

Meanwhile, Walter Pine is stressed about finding a suitable show for an empty afternoon slot on TV. His boss has warned him that he might lose his job if he fails. He tolerates his demanding boss because he needs the job to support his daughter, Amanda, as he is a single father. He recalls a recent visit from Elizabeth, who complained about Amanda's lunch being stolen.

Meanwhile, Elizabeth discovers that two months into her lab tech job at Hastings, Donatti has plagiarized her research and published it under his own name in *Science Journal*, crediting Boryweitz as a co-author. Outraged, she confronts them and resigns. Back home, Harriet informs Elizabeth about calls from Walter, and Madeline is shocked to learn that Elizabeth spoke to Amanda's father. Madeline tries to explain that she only shared her lunch with Amanda because she thought Amanda's needed better foods in her diet. However, despite Madeline's protest, Elizabeth insists that stealing is wrong.

Meanwhile, Madeline's teacher, Mrs. Mudford, disapproves of both Amanda and Madeline. She dislikes Amanda for being difficult, which she attributes to Amanda's being raised by a single father. She also disapproves of Madeline for her advanced skills and boyish interests, like wanting to read the work of Vladimir Nabokov.

Madeline expresses her dislike for school and asks Elizabeth about their financial status. Her questions lead Elizabeth to recall finding letters among Calvin's things, including offers from top universities. She knows he only accepted his role at Hastings because of the weather in Southern California. All the other offers would have given him much better pay than Hastings, which paid him an insultingly low amount, thanks to Donatti.

While going through Calvin's things, Elizabeth also finds a letter in which he expresses hatred toward his father. This confuses Elizabeth, who was under the impression that Calvin's father was dead. Additionally, there are also letters from people claiming to be relatives, including one from a woman claiming to be his biological mother and offering money for his research.

Here, the novel comes full circle and returns to where it started; Walter has just met with Elizabeth, who is upset because Amanda has been eating Madeline's lunch. Walter and Elizabeth are in similar situations: they are single parents with jobs they tolerate for the sake of their children.



Despite what the start of the novel may suggest, Elizabeth does not leave her job at Hastings for a cooking show on television—rather, she leaves Hastings on principle, and the television job happens to fall into her lap. Although Elizabeth is willing to put up with a lot for Madeline's sake, there are some lines that she will not allow Donatti to cross. Unfortunately, for the moment, she is once again left without a job.



Like her mother, Madeline is a problem for a social space that does not know how to handle her. Vladimir Nabokov, the author Madeline is reading, is most famous for his novel [Lolita](#), which tells the story of a pedophile preying upon an adolescent girl. Its content was controversial among adults, and, for obvious reasons, it was not considered appropriate for children.



Elizabeth knows the current situation is not tenable and, once again, she finds that Donatti is to blame for her problems. Unfortunately, Calvin never cared about Donatti's interference while he was alive because he did not have a child to think about.



Here, Elizabeth learns that there were many things she never learned about Calvin because his death cut their relationship short. She also gets a sense of what it is like to be in Calvin's shoes, with many people claiming they're related to him in order to be close to a famous person. The detail of the woman claiming to be his biological mother offering him money, though, suggests that her claim might be legitimate: if she were merely an opportunist, why would she offer him money? This question remains unanswered for now and so builds intrigue.



Later, as Elizabeth is eating dinner, Walter calls her with a proposal for her to host a cooking show. Although she dislikes the idea of being reduced to a TV cook, she considers it due to the attractive pay, especially after quitting her job at Hastings.

The proposal for Elizabeth to host a cooking show introduces a dilemma between financial stability and personal integrity. On the one hand, she does not want to be a cultural representative for keeping women in the home. However, on the other hand, she needs money in order to provide for Madeline.



CHAPTER 24: THE AFTERNOON DEPRESSION ZONE

Phil Lebensmal, the executive producer at KCTV and Walter's boss, instructs Walter to style Elizabeth provocatively for TV, suggesting skin-tight outfits. He also recommends that each episode features a cocktail-making segment. However, Elizabeth refuses every dress, finding them uncomfortable, and proposes wearing a lab coat instead. She also inquires about the lab equipment she requested for **the kitchen set**, but Walter falsely claims it's not ready.

Walter has the difficult task of trying to please both his boss and Elizabeth, who have opposite ideas for what they want the show to be. Lebensmal wants Elizabeth to look and act like an attractive housewife, while Elizabeth wants to challenge how the media portrays women. Here, Walter begins realizing that he will not be able to fully meet the demands of either.



In reality, **the set**, designed like a tacky kitchen and lacking the requested equipment, is complete, but Walter knows Elizabeth will dislike it. He tells Elizabeth that her role is to entertain, especially since her show, *Supper at Six*, will air during the "Afternoon Depression Zone," a period between 1:30 and 5:00 p.m. known for low productivity. This timeslot is usually filled with children's programs or game shows to provide mental relaxation for housewives. Elizabeth's show is scheduled at 4:30 p.m. and targets homemakers who need a boost to start preparing dinner.

The tacky kitchen set and the lack of proper equipment showcase the gulf between Elizabeth's expectations for her show and the reality of the entertainment industry.



Walter expresses his condolences for Calvin's death and empathizes with Elizabeth, but he advises against sharing those personal details with the show's producers. He worries they will not take it well and wish to fire her. Walter also reveals he is not Amanda's biological father but loves her deeply. Amanda's mother once threatened to take Amanda away from him during their divorce proceedings, but she never followed through because she did not actually care about her daughter.

Walter's attempt to protect Elizabeth's job by advising her to keep her personal life private reflects the harsh realities of professional life in the 1960s where personal struggles may be seen as liabilities. Luckily, this is a place where he and Elizabeth see eye to eye, as she has no interest in making Calvin part of her public identity.



As Walter and Elizabeth are getting to know each other, they discover that Mrs. Mudford has summoned them regarding their respective children. Both dislike Mrs. Mudford's implied judgment of how they choose to parent their children. Then, switching back to the topic at hand, Walter suggests Elizabeth wear something from her own wardrobe for the show, as wearing a lab coat isn't an option. Although they do not see eye-to-eye on everything, Elizabeth likes Walter and thinks he is a good man.

Mrs. Mudford's summons suggests that she is biased against Walter and Elizabeth because they are single parents. While Madeline may be an unusual child because she is so advanced, there is no reason to consider her a problem, though Mrs. Mudford thinks otherwise. Meanwhile, Walter's suggestion for Elizabeth to choose her attire is a gesture that acknowledges her need to retain a sense of personal identity amidst the new role she's taking on.



CHAPTER 25: THE AVERAGE JANE

Elizabeth makes her first appearance on the live show, wearing a plain dress with a **pencil** in her hair and holding test tubes. Disgusted by **the set**, she openly criticizes it on air and walks off to talk to Walter, leading to an abrupt commercial break. Walter tells her that the set, designed for the average housewife, cannot be altered. This upsets Elizabeth, who feels she has been misled. Back on camera, Elizabeth disregards the cue cards and captivates female viewers with her talk on the underappreciation of wives, mothers, and women, vowing to make her daily 30 minutes on screen meaningful to their lives.

Elizabeth's unscripted behavior infuriates Lebensmal, who angrily confronts Walter and threatens to cancel the show. Despite Walter's pleas, Elizabeth stands by her conscience and refuses to read the cue cards. Despite Lebensmal and Walter's concerns, the show generates numerous calls inquiring about a shopping list Elizabeth mentioned, a level of engagement that Walter's other afternoon shows have never achieved.

Elizabeth does not seem to recognize—or care—that she is on live television. Walter worries that she has doomed them from the start by openly expressing her disgust for their new viewers to see. However, Elizabeth feels betrayed and does not care how she is coming off to the viewers. As such, she ignores everything Walter tells her and speaks from the heart. Rather than make a promise to Walter, she makes a promise to her female viewers.



Lebensmal, like Donatti, is furious that a woman would undermine him the way Elizabeth has, so he flexes his power to try to get the show back under his control. Although Elizabeth is unconcerned with Lebensmal, Walter believes they will only be able to defy him for so long before they are kicked off the air.



CHAPTER 26: THE FUNERAL

Two weeks into the broadcast, Walter is completely worn out. Despite his exhaustion, Elizabeth keeps insisting on changing **the kitchen set**. She also ignores the cue cards, weaving scientific facts into her cooking segments instead. In an effort to show her how dull her approach is, Walter introduces a live audience, hoping it will push her toward a more engaging style.

Contrary to Walter's expectations, Elizabeth starts her show by decluttering **the kitchen set**, handing out most of the items to the audience. While preparing a spinach casserole, she educates the audience about the health benefits of spinach and comparing cooking to chemistry. She encourages her viewers to be adventurous in the kitchen and concludes the show with her memorable line: "Children, set the table. Your mother needs a moment to herself."

During the taping, Walter is so overwhelmed that he imagines his own funeral. He's brought back to reality by his secretary and Elizabeth, who notice him slumped over with a racing heart. Elizabeth offers him the spinach casserole she just prepared. Despite his initial reluctance due to Amanda's dislike for spinach, he takes it home. Contrary to what he assumed, Amanda ends up loving the casserole, calling it the best dish she's ever had.

Walter likes Elizabeth, but he also wants to keep his job, and he feels like Supper at Six might be the end of him. Still, so far, the show has been allowed to continue, and Walter sees an opportunity to improve it by adding a live audience.



Here, Elizabeth finds a way to personalize her set while also making the show entertaining for her audience. She also remains steadfast in making sure her show speaks to women and acknowledges the hard work they do to maintain their domestic spaces. As usual, she does not care about the consequences her bosses—who are men—might have in mind for her.



Walter is not threatened by Elizabeth's feminism or how she conducts herself. However, he is scared of Lebensmal, who does find Elizabeth's behavior threatening and unacceptable. While Elizabeth may feel like she has done a great thing, Walter worries that both of their children might go hungry if their parents lose their jobs.



CHAPTER 27: ALL ABOUT ME

In May 1961, Mrs. Mudford assigns her class a project to create family trees. Harriet, feeling the assignment is just a nosy endeavor by Mrs. Mudford to pry into their lives, criticizes it, believing that basing one's identity on one's ancestors is misguided. Additionally, Harriet learns from a conversation with Madeline that many of Madeline's classmates are bringing leftovers from dishes featured on Elizabeth's cooking show, revealing its unexpected popularity. Harriet is surprised, as she had doubted the show's success due to Elizabeth's serious demeanor and the integration of chemistry lessons. She had been advising Elizabeth to conform to the producers' and sponsors' expectations because she did not think housewives would like the product Elizabeth was selling. However, Elizabeth adamantly refused to comply, not wanting to reinforce stereotypes about women's incompetence.

Although Harriet and Elizabeth share a close friendship and agree on many things, they differ in their views on gender roles. Elizabeth, unlike Harriet, firmly believes that the societal limitations on women and the perceived superiority of men are cultural constructs, not biological truths.

Madeline, meanwhile, is worried about her inability to complete the family tree due to her limited knowledge about Calvin. Harriet comforts her, accidentally revealing that Calvin had a kind of "fairy godmother." Harriet learned this information while snooping around the apartment, where she found a letter from the boys home he grew up in. The letter was asking for donations because the home had just lost a major benefactor.

Harriet pieces together that the donor was making donations on Calvin's behalf and stopped after he left the home. Despite Madeline's curiosity about her father's past, Harriet insists she keep the assignment hidden from Elizabeth. Instead, Madeline starts asking Harriet questions that Harriet is not equipped to answer. Overwhelmed, she decides to take Madeline to the library, where she can do research.

Mrs. Mudford's assignment is sure to be a problem for Madeline, who never knew her father or the truth about his parentage. Furthermore, Elizabeth, who already has a difficult time discussing her family, is sure to dislike the assignment if she learns about it. The dishes Madeline's classmates are bringing into school demonstrate that Supper at Six has a far wider reach than the men in charge at the local station are giving it credit for. Whether they want to admit it or not, Elizabeth is having a positive impact on the health of the local population while also providing a voice for women.



Elizabeth is a woman far ahead of her time, as the ideas she expresses here reflect the ideals of both second and third-wave feminism. Second-wave feminism was just getting underway in the early 1960s, while third-wave feminism would not come about until the 1990s.



Harriet's accidental disclosure of a "fairy godmother" associated with Calvin adds a new dimension to his past and raises questions about the identity of the benefactor who supported the boys home. This revelation suggests a hidden figure in Calvin's life, perhaps the same one who has been making donations to the Hastings Institute.



Despite Madeline's curiosity about her father, Harriet wants to keep the assignment from Elizabeth because she feels like Elizabeth might not allow it to go further. Harriet wants Madeline to complete the project because she thinks it will be good for her in the long run. Additionally, Harriet tends to snoop and would like to know the truth for herself.



CHAPTER 28: SAINTS

Madeline seeks help from the librarian to locate a boys home in Iowa. Reverend Wakely, is in the library and overhears her. He assists in identifying the home, relying on the limited information she provides. During their search, they discuss the challenges of Wakely's job as a reverend. Wakely also shares his thoughts on the difference between something being secret and something being private. He claims that everyone, including himself, has secrets.

Together, they pinpoint the All Saints Boys Home, but only find a phone number rather than an address. Wakely volunteers to call for Madeline and is shocked to learn that her deceased father is Calvin Evans, someone he once knew. Wakely had corresponded with Calvin after being impressed by his remarks at a Harvard conference. Despite their differences, they formed a mutual respect. However, their relationship ended abruptly after Calvin wrote a letter wishing for his father's death. Wakely did not know how to respond to the letter, so he never did.

Years later, after taking over his father's congregation, Wakely had intended to reconnect with Calvin, only to learn of his death. After discovering what happened to Calvin, Wakely officiated his funeral, where he saw Elizabeth and Six-Thirty. Madeline shows Wakely a family photo from the funeral, featuring Calvin's coffin, Elizabeth (who was pregnant with Madeline at the time) and Six-Thirty. Touched by Madeline's situation, Wakely remarks that families don't always conform to the structure of a tree. Before leaving, Madeline confides a secret to Wakely, who reciprocates with one of his own. Madeline's revelation astonishes Wakely, while she reassures him that his secret isn't too alarming.

Madeline's encounter with Reverend Wakely at the library is another one of the book's significant and fateful coincidences. The distinction Wakely makes between secrets and privacy suggests that people can keep secrets to respect the sanctity of their inner life, not necessarily out of shame. As such, secrecy is not necessarily a bad thing.



Wakely's relationship with Calvin was full of mutual respect, even though they arrived at their conclusions through different frameworks. Calvin, in this case, represents the scientific worldview, while Wakely represents the religious worldview. However, the limits of their respect are tested after the death of Calvin's father. Wakely knows he cannot console Calvin using religion and is thus at a loss for words.



Wakely's parting observation that families don't always conform to the structure of a tree is a reflection on the nature of family and the many forms it can take. For Wakely, family goes beyond the biological and legal structures. The secrets Wakely and Madeline exchange solidify the forming of a new friendship. Other than Harriet and perhaps Amanda, Wakely is Madeline's only friend and confidant, just as he was for Calvin.



CHAPTER 29: BONDING

During an episode of her show, Elizabeth teaches about various chemical bonds while making a chicken pot pie. Walter is concerned while watching her performance because Lebensmal, having renewed Elizabeth's contract for another six months, insists on reducing the science content and adding more sex appeal. Walter tries to get Elizabeth to meet him halfway, but Elizabeth ignores his suggestions and continues with her scientific approach, which the female viewers appreciate for making them feel capable.

Elizabeth's cooking show has become a platform not only for culinary arts but also for the empowerment and education of her audience. Her refusal to diminish the educational aspect of her show, despite pressure from Lebensmal, demonstrates her dedication to empowering her female viewers, who value the show's informative approach and who would not benefit from increasing the sex appeal of the show.



Near the end of the episode, with some time to spare, Elizabeth takes a question from the audience. A woman asks her a complex question about leg edema, applying concepts Elizabeth had covered in previous episodes. It turns out the woman, a housewife whose husband routinely insults her intelligence, enjoys reading medical journals and once aspired to be an open-heart surgeon. This revelation earns applause from the audience. Elizabeth encourages the woman to chase her dream, emphasizing that it's never too late. As a gesture of support for the woman's bold future, Elizabeth gifts her the chicken pot pie she just made on the show.

The interaction with the woman from the audience highlights the unexpected capabilities of Elizabeth's female viewers. The gift of the chicken pot pie to the woman serves as a symbolic gesture of support for her aspirations, linking the act of cooking to the nurturing of one's goals and dreams. More specifically, it reinforces the importance of women helping to support and encourage other women. The implication in this scene is that there are many women in Elizabeth's audience who feel the same way—it is a large part of the reason they are drawn to the show in the first place.



CHAPTER 30: 99 PERCENT

Elizabeth receives a call from Mrs. Mudford about the family photograph that Madeline included with her family tree assignment. Elizabeth, who never learned of the assignment, does not know what she is talking about. After Elizabeth finishes speaking with Mrs. Mudford, Harriet tells her that the reverend (Wakely) from the First Presbyterian Church has been inquiring about Madeline. Additionally, the LA Times has been repeatedly calling the house because they want an interview with Elizabeth. However, Elizabeth is not interested in doing interviews because she does not want herself or Madeline exposed to the public eye.

Mrs. Mudford's call about the family photograph reveals that Elizabeth has isolated herself against what is going on in her own home, as this is the first time she has heard about the assignment. Although Wakely has good intentions for calling, his call is one among many Elizabeth has received since starting her show, which makes her wonder whether her job (and the publicity that comes with it) is going to end up hurting Madeline.



Walter calls Elizabeth to sympathize over Amanda's troubles with the family tree project and informs her of Lebensmal's dissatisfaction with the show. He asks Elizabeth to feature a canned soup from a potential sponsor in an upcoming episode to make things better. Rather than respond to Walter's suggestion, Elizabeth suggests that she meet with Lebensmal in person. However, Walter forbids her from ever doing so, especially if she is alone.

Walter's call shows his concern for Elizabeth's wellbeing, but also conveys the pressure from Lebensmal regarding the show's direction. Walter forbids Elizabeth from seeing Lebensmal by herself, partly because he knows the meeting will end poorly, and partly because he seems to think Lebensmal is a dangerous man.



The week worsens as Mrs. Mudford starts spreading gossip about the children's families, revealing sensitive information about Madeline and Amanda. Additionally, Elizabeth discovers she is being paid significantly less than her male colleagues at KCTV and is excluded from profit-sharing opportunities. The same day, she comes home from work and sees that Harriet has suffered an injury because Mr. Sloane through a bottle at her in a drunken rage. Despite Elizabeth's fury, Harriet refuses to involve the police and insists on handling the situation herself.

The incident with Harriet and Mr. Sloane introduces a domestic violence subplot, adding another problematic situation Elizabeth feels she must confront, despite already dealing with multiple stressors. Harriet's reluctance to involve the police is a common reaction in such situations, reflecting the complex emotions and fears involved in abusive relationships.



The next day, Elizabeth openly criticizes the sponsor's soup on her show and assures her audience that it will harm them if they ingest it. She also addresses the gender pay gap before demonstrating how to make a broccoli-mushroom casserole from scratch.

Elizabeth's on-air criticism of the sponsor's soup and her discussion of the gender pay gap are acts of defiance that ensure her show is made to benefit the women watching it.



After her latest performance, Lebensmal summons Elizabeth for a meeting, and despite Rosa's warning not to go alone, Elizabeth confronts him. Lebensmal tries to intimidate her, and when that fails, he fires her and everyone else on the show. Unfazed, Elizabeth accuses him of wanting a show that upholds societal norms and limits women. In a final show of power, Lebensmal undresses in front of her and moves toward her. In response, Elizabeth pulls a large knife out of her purse, the sight of which causes Lebensmal to faint.

Unlike her earlier encounter with Dr. Meyers, Elizabeth knows what to expect from Lebensmal and is prepared for him when he attempts to assault her. Given that this is the second instance of attempted sexual assault in the novel, there is a broader suggestion that such occurrences happen often and disallow women from being able to feel safe at work.



CHAPTER 31: THE GET-WELL CARD

Lebensmal suffers a heart attack and is hospitalized for three weeks, followed by an entire year of bed rest, making work impossible for him. Walter is shocked to discover that Elizabeth was present during the incident and called for an ambulance. He is also appalled to learn that Elizabeth met Lebensmal alone in the evening, despite his warnings against it.

Elizabeth's proactive measures during Lebensmal's heart attack demonstrate her quick thinking and willingness to help even the most despicable people when they are in need. Her presence of mind to call an ambulance likely saves Lebensmal's life.



Elizabeth reveals to Walter that Lebensmal fired the entire team before attempting to assault her. She also tells him that Lebensmal's heart attack was the result of her pulling out a knife—the same knife she uses on her show. While waiting for the ambulance, Elizabeth took the opportunity to look through documents in Lebensmal's office. She discovered that contrary to Lebensmal's claims, *Supper at Six* has actually been performing very well and has even had offers for syndication and new sponsorships.

Elizabeth's discovery of the show's success and Lebensmal's deceptive practices reveals the underhandedness of his management. Clearly, *Supper at Six* has great potential, as it has remained relatively popular even with Lebensmal sabotaging it. The discovery of this information gives Elizabeth and Walter the leverage to take control of the situation and move the show in a more positive direction.



With Lebensmal incapacitated, Walter steps up as the acting executive producer. He successfully syndicates the show nationwide and secures new sponsorship deals, significantly boosting revenue. When updating the KCTV staff about Lebensmal's health, the news of his heart attack is met with applause, reflecting his unpopularity. The staff sends a get-well card to Lebensmal, filled with remarks that show their disdain for him. Inspired by Elizabeth's advice to tell Lebensmal what he really thinks of him, Walter boldly writes on the card, "MAY YOU NEVER RECOVER."

The staff's reaction to Lebensmal's heart attack and the get-well card's sarcastic remarks indicate his lack of popularity and the negative impact he had on the workplace environment. Walter's decision to follow Elizabeth's advice and express his true feelings toward Lebensmal reflects the deep resentment he harbors toward him, which he previously did not have the courage to express.



CHAPTER 32: MEDIUM RARE

Harriet decides to sneak Madeline out of school to see Elizabeth live on **the Supper at Six set**. They plan to enter discreetly through the emergency exit and sit in the back row unnoticed. However, when they arrive, they find a massive crowd already gathered, hoping to get into the show. A security guard informs them that the audience has been pre-selected: they can't enter, as people have been waiting since the early hours of the morning. Cleverly, Madeline asks the security guard to write his name in her notebook, under the pretense of telling her mother about his challenging job. When the security guard sees Madeline's last name in the notebook, he immediately realizes who she is and takes her and Harriet inside.

Once inside, Walter's secretary offers Harriet and Madeline front-row seats, which they accept after ensuring that the bright lights will prevent Elizabeth from seeing them. Madeline watches her mother with pride but also feels a twinge of jealousy, realizing she has to share her mother with the show's vast audience.

Walter, concerned, meets with Harriet and Madeline, questioning why Madeline isn't in school. He warns that Elizabeth might be upset if she finds out Madeline is there, explaining that Elizabeth's intention is to shield her daughter from the invasive nature of fame. Madeline, curious, asks Walter about Elizabeth's popularity, to which Walter responds that Elizabeth is popular because of her exceptional cooking and her rare honesty.

After speaking with Walter, Harriet and Madeline return to the audience to watch Elizabeth. In a bold move at the end of the show, Elizabeth, in response to an audience question, declares herself an atheist. This revelation leads to a flurry of phone calls to Walter as the episode wraps up. Unlike the previous phone calls Walter received about the show, many people are unhappy with what Elizabeth had to say.

CHAPTER 33: FAITH

In 1960, Elizabeth's public declaration of atheism is shocking and results in widespread controversy, even from her most devoted fans. Walter starts receiving threats from sponsors and viewers who wish harm upon Elizabeth. Despite the turmoil, Elizabeth encourages Walter to have faith that everything will turn out fine.

Harriet's decision to bring Madeline to the Supper at Six set shows her determination to support Madeline's connection with her mother, despite the potential for disruption. Madeline's quick thinking to gain access by leveraging the security guard's recognition of her last name indicates her understanding of the influence her mother's fame can wield. Although Elizabeth has tried to hide her professional life from Madeline, Madeline has some understanding of it because of her interactions with kids at school.



Harriet and Madeline's discreet presence in the front row allows Madeline to witness her mother's success firsthand. Madeline's mixed emotions of pride and jealousy reveal a sacrifice she did not know she was making—that is, sharing her mother with the world.



Walter's conversation with Madeline about Elizabeth's popularity reinforces the show's appeal and Elizabeth's authentic approach, which resonates with the audience. Walter's answer is something that Lebensmal never grasped or, if he did grasp it, did not care about it. Meanwhile, Walter shows here that he is aware of what Elizabeth is doing and considers it important work.



The flurry of phone calls Walter receives as the episode concludes are not like the phone calls he received after the show first aired. Although Elizabeth's audience accepts and enjoys her feminism, atheism is a step too far for many of them. At the time, the American public would have considered atheism a radical position—even more radical than feminism.



Elizabeth's declaration of atheism in the year 1960 places her in the midst of a social and cultural maelstrom. At that time, such a public admission would have been especially controversial, challenging the prevailing norms and expectations of public figures.



Meanwhile, Reverend Wakely is grappling with his own faith after a challenging day. He returns to his office and finds his new part-time typist, Frask, watching *Supper at Six* while working. Frask reveals that she previously worked with Elizabeth at Hastings before they were both fired.

Frask's casual viewing of Supper at Six while working, and her past connection to Elizabeth, suggests that Elizabeth's influence extends into unexpected corners of her community.



Wakely, surprised, meets with Madeline and questions why she hadn't mentioned her mother's television presence. Madeline, under the impression that Elizabeth's TV role was common knowledge, especially after her atheist announcement, is taken aback by his unawareness. Wakely then shares with Madeline his fruitless efforts to confirm Calvin Evans's connection with the All Saints Boys Home. Despite multiple attempts to contact the bishop and the secretary finally telling him that they had no record of Calvin Evans, Madeline remains skeptical, convinced that the secretary is not being truthful.

Wakely's surprise indicates a disconnect between different social circles and the varying degrees of public awareness. Seemingly every woman in the community knows about Supper at Six, yet it is barely on his radar. Additionally, Madeline's conversation with Wakely about Calvin's past hints at potential cover-ups or lost records, deepening the mystery surrounding Calvin's early life.



CHAPTER 34: ALL SAINTS

The bishop of All Saints recalls how in 1933, he was tasked with securing long-term funding for the Iowa boys home, after which he would be transferred to a better location. He had no success until 1937, when a man named Wilson from the Parker Foundation (a wealthy Catholic organization) came looking for Calvin Evans with the intention of adopting him. The bishop had been expecting that Wilson was planning to give him money, which the home desperately needed.

The bishop's recollection provides a startling twist to the history of Calvin and the All Saints Boys Home. By falsely claiming Calvin's death and suggesting the creation of a memorial fund, the bishop secured financial support for the home through unethical means, making him yet another religious figure in the novel with questionable morals.



As such, the bishop lied and told Wilson that Calvin was dead, and he suggested setting up a donor fund in his name. Shocked, Wilson agreed to establish the Calvin Evans Memorial Fund, which would be dedicated to science and sports. However, when Calvin later appeared on the cover of "Chemistry Today," Avery Parker of the Parker Foundation called, furious to learn that Calvin was in fact alive, and the endowment was canceled.

The bishop manipulated Calvin's life and identity for financial gain, casting a shadow over his early years and the motives of those who were responsible for his care. Eventually, his scheme blew up in his face, but not before ruining Calvin's life and ensuring he would never meet his biological father.



In the present, the bishop, weary of past complications related to Calvin, has been evading Wakely's calls. To confirm Madeline's doubts, Wakely contacts the home again, posing as a potential donor inquiring about Calvin Evans. This leads to an admission from the bishop that Calvin was indeed raised there and the revelation of the Parker Foundation's involvement in the Calvin Evans Memorial Fund.

The bishop's admission confirms the existence of the Calvin Evans Memorial Fund and the Parker Foundation's involvement, shedding light on a part of Calvin's past that was shrouded in secrecy. The bishop's cagey behavior does not surprise Wakely, suggesting that there are many people in Wakely's profession who similarly abuse their power.



Wakely shares this information with Madeline, including the post box number for the Parker Foundation, hinting that Wilson might have been her “fairy godmother.” Madeline is puzzled by the Foundation’s decision to fund and then withdraw support for a memorial in her father’s name while he was still alive. Despite the mystery, she remains determined to uncover the truth, impressing Wakely with her insight that faith is not exclusively tied to religion.

Once again, Madeline is wise well beyond her years. She manages to find holes in the bishop’s story that Wakely himself missed, while also articulating philosophical views on the nature of faith. Although Madeline disentangles faith from religion, she does not appear to have a negative attitude toward religion like her mother.



CHAPTER 35: THE SMELL OF FAILURE

When one of Elizabeth’s viewers asks for a diet tip on her show, Elizabeth recommends rowing as an exercise option. This advice leads to an unexpected surge of women at the boathouse, all eager to follow her suggestion.

Elizabeth’s recommendation of rowing as a form of exercise demonstrates her influence as a public figure: her words have the power to motivate a significant behavioral change among her viewers.



Meanwhile, protesters opposing Elizabeth’s openly declared atheism gather outside KCTV. Elizabeth remains unbothered, but Walter is deeply concerned, especially since Elizabeth has been receiving numerous death threats. Six-Thirty is also anxious and becomes particularly wary of a person in the television audience who doesn’t applaud. He sneaks into the studio, bypassing security. Inside, Elizabeth introduces Six-Thirty as her dog. The security guard who talked with Harriet and Madeline tells her that he already knows the dog because it came with them when they visited the studio. Elizabeth immediately gets angry because she never gave Madeline permission to come to the studio.

The protesters outside KCTV reflect the contentious nature of Elizabeth’s statement on atheism. Walter’s concern over Elizabeth’s safety contrasts with her composed demeanor, illustrating the courage she maintains in the face of adversity. The only thing that bothers Elizabeth is when she learns that Madeline has been to the studio to see her in action. Suddenly, the religious protests surrounding Elizabeth feel more real because she knows her daughter has become involved in her professional life.



To appease Elizabeth, Walter lies and says that Madeline’s visit was due to a homework assignment, “Watch Your Parent at Work Day.” During this conversation, Walter inadvertently agrees to let Six-Thirty appear on the show, where the dog quickly becomes a favorite among the audience. However, Six-Thirty remains vigilant, particularly focused on the suspicious non-clapper.

Walter’s fabrication of “Watch Your Parent at Work Day” underscores his protective instinct toward both Elizabeth and Madeline. He does not want to throw Harriet under the bus, and he secretly thinks that it was good that Madeline got to see her mother in action, even if he does not say so.



Six-Thirty spots the non-clapper once he is off-stage and decides to investigate. There, he detects the smell of nitroglycerin in her handbag. He cleverly moves the bag closer to a security guard. Upon inspection, the guard finds dynamite sticks and flyers inside, labeling Elizabeth a “godless Communist.” He promptly alerts the police. Further investigation confirms that this woman was responsible for all the death threats against Elizabeth.

Here, Six-Thirty shows that he would have been a great bomb-sniffing dog, if only the people training him had shown him love the way Elizabeth has. Evidently, the woman with the bomb was a religious extremist who believes Elizabeth represents a threat to the woman’s values. Although Elizabeth never says anything about communism, the woman calls her a “godless Communist,” conveying the American public’s prejudice against communism and the threat to the so-called American way of life it supposedly posed.



CHAPTER 36: LIFE AND DEATH

Elizabeth receives another offer, this time from *Life* magazine, for an interview. Just as she has done before, she rejects it because she does not want to subject her family to an invasive interviewer. Walter, who has grown fond of Harriet and developed feelings for her, seeks Harriet's assistance to persuade Elizabeth into accepting the interview.

Life magazine's Franklin Roth arrives the next week to watch Elizabeth's live show. He quickly realizes that Elizabeth is unwilling to participate in the interview and, respecting her autonomy, decides to leave. However, Elizabeth, wanting to continue, asks a security guard to stop Roth. She then invites Roth to her home, showcasing her laboratory and the rowing machine. She also discusses her research on abiogenesis. Initially, the interview lacks excitement, so Roth boldly asks about Calvin, even though he told himself he wouldn't. At first, Roth thinks he has ruined the interview. However, to his surprise, Elizabeth begins telling him the story of her time with Calvin.

Elizabeth's steadfast refusal to engage with invasive media interviews is a testament to her priority of protecting her family's privacy. Despite the potential benefits that a feature in Life magazine could bring, she does not give in, determined to continue to protect her family.



Roth's decision to leave after realizing Elizabeth's reluctance is an act of professional courtesy that is seemingly rare in his industry. His demeanor impresses Elizabeth, causing her to have a sudden change of heart. She eager to share with Roth until Calvin's name comes up, causing her to worry that he is just like every other reporter. Nonetheless, she decides to put her faith in him and tell him the truth about her life with Calvin.



CHAPTER 37: SOLD OUT

Elizabeth describes Calvin as her "soulmate" to Roth, who is surprised by her use of language. She highlights how Calvin valued her work, passion, and skills—a rarity among men, in her experience. Elizabeth also discloses how Donatti plagiarized her research. She also talks about her experiences at UCLA and opens up about her family. Additionally, she discusses Calvin's upbringing and how she feels guilty about the role she played in his death.

Although Elizabeth reveals considerable personal information, Roth decides not to include any of it in his article. He writes about abiogenesis instead. His editor, seeking sensational content about Elizabeth, pressures Roth for scandalous details, but Roth maintains that there aren't any. However, two months later, when the article is published, it's heavily modified. It focuses on Elizabeth's physical appeal and includes comments from Dr. Meyers, Mrs. Mudford, and Donatti, who derogatorily refers to her as "Luscious Lizzie." Mrs. Mudford contributes a picture of Madeline's family tree that erroneously shows Walter as a family member, leading to misguided speculation about Elizabeth's relationship with him. The magazine issue quickly sells out within a day.

Elizabeth's candid conversation with Roth is an intimate portrait of her life with Calvin, marked by mutual respect and intellectual companionship. Her openness about their relationship and her accusation against Donatti for plagiarism gives Roth an intimate look into her personal and professional lives.



Despite the depth and authenticity of Elizabeth's revelations, Roth's journalistic integrity comes into play as he opts to focus on her scientific endeavors rather than her personal life. This decision reflects Roth's respect for Elizabeth's privacy and his commitment to highlighting her professional contributions. However, the editorial manipulation of Roth's article highlights the media's power to distort and sensationalize, while the focus on Elizabeth's looks shows how the media objectifies and belittles women—even those as accomplished as Elizabeth.



CHAPTER 38: BROWNIES

In July 1961, the popularity of *Supper at Six* soars due to the *Life* magazine article. Feeling betrayed by Roth's apparent duplicity, Elizabeth stops responding to his calls and, overwhelmed by depression, ends up baking brownies on her show for several consecutive days. Harriet tries to shield Madeline from the article, but Madeline reads it anyway and gets upset due to how it falsely portrays her mother.

One evening, while Harriet is out, Wakely stops by to check on Madeline. Shortly after, Elizabeth arrives and recognizes Wakely from the funeral. Wakely knows that his presence is strange, and he does his best to explain himself. Luckily, Elizabeth does not appear concerned. Through Wakely, Elizabeth learns that Roth wrote a different article about her that he still intends to publish.

Roth had come to Elizabeth's home recently, but Madeline, following Harriet's instructions to not answer the door, didn't let him in. Roth left a manila envelope at the door, which Madeline read and then gave to Wakely. With Wakely out, Madeline left the envelope with Frask, who informed Wakely that Madeline was very upset.

Elizabeth is annoyed that so many people are going through her private mail. Wakely gives the envelope to Elizabeth, revealing Roth's new, unpublished article titled "Why Their Minds Matter" with a sub-heading about bias in science and women's efforts to counteract it. Accompanying the article is Roth's note, apologizing and explaining that he quit *Life* magazine. He has been trying to get his truthful article published elsewhere, but it has been rejected by 10 scientific journals.

Still, Madeline is upset because about everything that her mother has to endure. She does not think it is fair. Madeline tells Elizabeth that she knows that Hastings treated her unfairly because Wakely's typist told her the truth. When Elizabeth asks Wakely about this typist, he reveals that it is someone Elizabeth knows.

The Life magazine article, for better or for worse, contributes to the increased popularity of Supper at Six. Elizabeth's response to the article—baking brownies repeatedly on her show—is a coping mechanism for dealing with the stress that the article misrepresentation caused her.



Here, characters who have remained largely separate throughout the narrative begin to link up. Although Wakely fears he will look suspicious, Elizabeth immediately trusts him because of his relationship with Calvin. Although Wakely does not know it, Elizabeth actually knows him quite well from reading his letters.



Roth dislikes how the article came out and wants to make it up to Elizabeth. He also does not want her to think badly of him, as he genuinely enjoyed their time together. However, a series of coincidences led him to be unable to deliver his message to Elizabeth in a timely fashion.



Roth's struggle to find a publisher for this article suggests that sensationalist media is much easier to sell than thoughtful, substantive journalism. However, Roth's decision to continue to shop the article demonstrates that he knows Elizabeth has been treated poorly—in part because of him—and he wants to make things right.



Madeline's reaction to the article shows the personal impact such public portrayals can have on family members. It also underscores Madeline's protective feelings toward her mother.



CHAPTER 39: DEAR SIRs

Two days before Wakely showed up at Elizabeth's apartment, Madeline had gone to Wakely's office carrying the manila envelope. There, Frask recognized Madeline due to her resemblance to Calvin. Frask tells Madeline that she knew Calvin and that he loved Elizabeth very much. Frask also inadvertently revealed that Elizabeth had been fired for being pregnant with Madeline. Madeline left soon after, with Frask assuring her she would pass the envelope to Wakely. Curious, Frask opened the letter and then wrote to the editors of *Life* magazine, debunking the published article and exposing the truth about the situation at Hastings, including Donatti's plagiarism of Elizabeth's research.

In the next issue of *Life*, numerous letters from women across the country supporting Elizabeth appear, including Frask's letter. Harriet, excited, attempts to show these to Elizabeth, but Elizabeth shows no interest. The unpublished article by Roth, which many journals have rejected at this point, also fails to lift her spirits, as it seems no one is interested in the stories of women in science.

The same morning, Madeline reads a lunchbox note from Elizabeth that reflects a cynical view of people, indicative of Elizabeth's growing depression. It's now November 1961, and both Harriet and Madeline are concerned about Elizabeth's mental state. Harriet, pondering the situation, suddenly has an idea about a potential audience that might be genuinely interested in stories about women in science.

Frask's revelation to Madeline not only sheds light on the depth of Calvin's love for Elizabeth but also reveals the unfair circumstances surrounding Elizabeth's firing from Hastings. Frask feels that she owes Elizabeth, so she writes to Life to set the record straight. However, there is an open question about whether or not the editors of Life will care. After all, they seem to care more about selling copies of their magazine than truthfully representing Elizabeth.



The women's support of Elizabeth suggests that a wider cultural shift is taking place—and that Elizabeth is its figurehead. However, this new voice in the culture has yet to fully materialize, as Roth still struggles to get his article published.



Elizabeth's note to Madeline is a questionable parenting decision, as it seems to reflect her current emotional state rather than being useful information for her daughter to absorb. Harriet knows that Elizabeth's mindset is bad for everyone and begins working on a way to fix it.



CHAPTER 40: NORMAL

Elizabeth and Wakely spend an evening together on the back step of her house talking to each other. During their talk, Elizabeth reveals that she has read his letters to Calvin and shares that Calvin chose to work at Hastings partly because of Wakely's remarks about the climate.

Wakely recalls the secrets he and Madeline shared: Madeline told him about Six-Thirty's ability to understand 981 words while he confessed to her his disbelief in God. The conversation then shifts to Elizabeth's brother John and her lingering guilt over his suicide. Wakely perceives that Elizabeth needs to come to terms with John's fate and accept herself to find peace.

Elizabeth and Wakely's conversation on the back step of her house is a moment of deep personal connection, with Elizabeth sharing intimate details of her and Calvin's past. It is the type of conversation she has rarely had since Calvin's death.



Wakely and Elizabeth's exchange about the secrets reveals a mutual trust and understanding. Both are dealing with difficult issues in their lives that they have trouble reconciling, and they share those issues with each other. Notably, Wakely, perhaps the only upstanding religious character in the novel, does not believe in God.



Elizabeth, opening up further, confesses to Wakely that she empathizes with John's feelings and sometimes harbors thoughts of wanting to end her life. Wakely insightfully suggests that Elizabeth's real struggle is not a desire to escape her life, but rather a deep-seated yearning to fully re-engage with it.

Wakely's observation that Elizabeth's struggle may be less about a death wish and more about a deep longing to reconnect is a powerful insight, and it informs everything she does going forward.



CHAPTER 41: RECOMMIT

At the start of the next *Supper at Six* episode, Elizabeth shocks her audience by announcing her retirement, declaring it her final show. The previous evening, she went gone to inform Walter of her decision and unexpectedly found Harriet at his home. It turns out that Walter and Harriet have been carrying on an affair, which they planned to keep under wraps until Harriet's divorce was finalized. Upon learning about Elizabeth's decision to retire, both Walter and Harriet were moved to tears. Walter did not want *Supper at Six* to end, but he respects Elizabeth's decision and supports her.

Elizabeth's announcement of her retirement on Supper at Six is an end to a significant chapter in her life. Her decision to retire signifies a major turning point and suggests a need for personal reflection and possibly a new direction in her life. Meanwhile, the revelation of Walter and Harriet's affair, shows that Harriet is more willingly to step outside the bounds of conventional morality than she would have been before meeting Elizabeth.



During the episode, Elizabeth expresses her gratitude to the audience for their support, viewership, and their role in helping her make history. She updates them on Marjorie Fillis, the housewife who once aspired to be a heart surgeon. Marjorie has now swiftly completed her pre-med studies and been accepted into medical school. Elizabeth encourages all her female viewers to be brave enough to embrace change like Marjorie. She also acknowledges Harriet as a dear friend and shares the advice Harriet had given her years ago: to take time for herself daily and recommit.

Elizabeth's final episode is not just a farewell but a celebration of her impact and the progress of women who have been inspired by her. The story of Marjorie Fillis serves as a testament to the show's influence, which highlights the transformative power of encouragement regardless of societal expectations. Also, Elizabeth's mention of Harriet is her small way of thanking her friend for her help and guidance over the years.



The audience responds with enthusiastic applause as Elizabeth wraps up the show. In a spontaneous moment, Walter thinks of a fitting final line and displays it on a cue card: "This concludes your introduction to chemistry [...] Class dismissed." Elizabeth uses this line to end the episode, marking the conclusion of her journey on the show.

The audience's applause and Walter's impromptu cue card with the final line — "This concludes your introduction to chemistry [...] Class dismissed"—serves as a fitting tribute to Elizabeth's role as both an educator and a public figure. Previously, Elizabeth complained that Walter's writing on the cue cards was terrible, and this scene shows that he has evolved as a result of working with her.



CHAPTER 42: PERSONNEL

In January of 1962, despite the acclaim of *Supper at Six*, Elizabeth hasn't received any job offers from universities or research labs since leaving the show. Harriet tells Elizabeth that Hastings' Head of Personnel, a "Miss Frask," has called for her. Elizabeth is puzzled because she thought Frask was working for Wakely, and she cannot imagine that she would be back at Hastings. Elizabeth calls back, and after speaking with Frask's secretary, Miss Finch, she gets through to Frask. Frask praises Elizabeth for an article that featured her on a magazine cover and urges her to come in as soon as possible with Six-Thirty, mentioning that the abiogenesis investor has reappeared, drawn by Frask's letter in *Life* magazine.

When Elizabeth arrives at Frask's office, she meets Miss Finch, who is starstruck. Miss Finch asks Elizabeth to autograph her copy of *Vogue*, which features Elizabeth on its cover with the title "Why Their Minds Matter." Harriet sent Roth's unpublished article to *Vogue* but lost hope after months of silence. Yet, the article was eventually published. Frask then leads Elizabeth and Six-Thirty to Calvin's former lab, where the investor, Wilson, and Avery Parker are waiting. They warmly welcome Elizabeth and offer her a chance to resume her abiogenesis research at Hastings.

However, Elizabeth declines the offer because she does not wish to work at Hastings. As she prepares to leave, Donatti enters, surprised to see Elizabeth, Frask, and Avery. Wilson, now Frask's lawyer, informs Donatti that he is being fired due to Frask's *Life* magazine letter, which prompted the Foundation to investigate and uncover his wrongdoings. The Foundation, now a majority shareholder in Hastings, has appointed Frask as Head of Personnel and offers Elizabeth Donatti's former position as Director of Chemistry.

As Avery hands Donatti his termination notice, she suggests that the decision on his employment should be made by someone familiar with his work. Elizabeth, after a moment's consideration, hands Donatti a pen and tells him he has to leave his job because he is not smart enough.

The absence of job offers, despite Elizabeth's acclaim, indicates that her public success matters little to the Dr. Donattis of the world, who do not want women like Elizabeth at their institutions. The call from Miss Frask, who is now back at Hastings, piques Elizabeth's curiosity and offers an unexpected twist, given their prior history. Frask's praise of Elizabeth and the mention of the abiogenesis investor's return signal potential changes at Hastings that could involve Elizabeth.



*Elizabeth's encounter with Miss Finch is a reminder of her celebrity status and the impact her *Vogue* article has made. The article's publication, despite Harriet's initial doubts, indicates the recognition of Elizabeth's work and what it has meant to women across the country. Finally, it seems things are beginning to look up for Elizabeth, as Wilson and Avery Parker appear to be offering her a chance to start over at Hastings.*



*Elizabeth's refusal to return to Hastings demonstrates her unwillingness to be associated with an institution that previously wronged her. However, she begins to feel differently after Donatti's termination, which is a moment of poetic justice. The exposure of Donatti's misconduct, largely due to Frask's letter in *Life* magazine, is a start to rectifying past injustices.*



Elizabeth's delivery of the pen to Donatti, mirroring his earlier condescension, is a reversal of roles. Although Elizabeth intends to be ironic, there is some truth in what she says, as Donatti repeatedly proved himself incapable of running the institute.



CHAPTER 43: STILLBORN

Avery and Wilson revisit their job offer to Elizabeth and discuss plans to improve the laboratory. During the conversation, Wilson offhandedly brings up Calvin Evans's unfinished work. This triggers Elizabeth to connect the dots between the wealthy donor at Calvin's boys home and the man whom Calvin suspected in his diaries to be his father. Elizabeth becomes defensive, suspecting that Wilson is a blood relative of Calvin's who intends to take over Calvin's research. However, the situation takes an unexpected turn when Avery requests a private conversation with Elizabeth.

In their private discussion, Elizabeth confronts Avery about the connections between Wilson, Calvin, and All Saints. Avery responds with a heart-wrenching story about a teenage girl who becomes pregnant and is sent to a Catholic home for unwed mothers. Despite pressure to give up her child, she refuses. During a traumatic labor, she is left alone, sedated by a doctor, and then falsely told her baby was stillborn. A decade later, a nurse from the home reveals the truth: her son was actually adopted, but after his adoptive family tragically died, he was sent to a boys home in Iowa. Avery reveals she is that girl and thus Calvin's biological mother, who has been searching for her son ever since.

Elizabeth's defensive reaction upon hearing Wilson bring up Calvin's unfinished work is understandable given her protective stance over Calvin's legacy and her suspicions about Wilson's intentions. Her fear that a blood relative might be trying to usurp Calvin's research comes from what she has read about Calvin's past. However, Avery's demeanor and request for a private conversation implies there is still much Elizabeth does not know.



Avery's story is a sorrowful recounting of the practice of the time when medical professionals often coerced unwed mothers into giving up their children. The revelation that Avery is actually Calvin's biological mother puts Elizabeth in the strange position of knowing more about Calvin's parentage than he ever knew himself. This revelation reframes the narrative, shifting the perspective on Avery's intentions behind the offer to Elizabeth. It also provides closure to the mystery surrounding Calvin's parentage and the identity of the "fairy godmother" figure who had been making donations in his name.



CHAPTER 44: THE ACORN

Elizabeth reacts with shock and suspicion to Avery's revelation, questioning why Avery didn't come forward earlier. Avery explains that she had sent Wilson, her lawyer and the head of her foundation, to find Calvin. However, the bishop misled Wilson, claiming that Calvin was deceased. In response, Avery decided to support the home financially, dedicating funds to science and sports programs in honor of Calvin's father, who was a rower. Avery eventually learned the truth about Calvin being alive when she saw him on the cover of *Chemistry Today*, leading her to abruptly halt the funding and start writing to Calvin. Elizabeth recalls that the letters she saw from someone claiming to be Calvin's mother were indeed from Avery Parker.

Avery had been careful about reconnecting with Calvin. Wilson was sent to fund Elizabeth's research at Hastings after Avery discovered Elizabeth and Calvin's relationship. Initially, Donatti tried to divert Wilson and later falsely claimed Elizabeth was a man to dissuade him. Before Avery or Wilson could reach out to Calvin directly, he died, and Elizabeth's research stalled. Avery and Wilson even attended Calvin's funeral and thought they might meet Elizabeth there. Then, subsequently, the article misrepresenting Elizabeth's feelings for Calvin came out, quoting her as saying she barely knew him.

Here, all the narrative threads of the novel begin to connect. Avery was kept away from her son due to a mix of bad luck and back people. Although she always wanted to reunite with Calvin, she also knew that it was best to keep an appropriate distance and not force herself on him. As Avery is telling her story, Elizabeth knows she is telling the truth because of the letters she has seen with her own eyes. The more Avery talks, the less skeptical Elizabeth becomes, as she starts to realize that Avery is a good and truthful person.



This moment sheds light on the actions and motivations of Donatti, who obstructs the truth and Elizabeth's professional progress. Additionally, the article misrepresenting Elizabeth's feelings for Calvin adds to the tragedy of the situation, as it not only distorted Elizabeth's true sentiments but also further complicated the potential for Avery to make contact with Elizabeth.



Hearing this, Elizabeth is overwhelmed with emotion. She affirms her deep love for Calvin, whom she considers the best thing in her life. In a moment of profound happiness and sadness, Elizabeth lays her head on Avery's shoulder and cries like never before, mourning the loss of Calvin and the years of misunderstandings and missed connections.

In a cathartic moment of shared grief and happiness, Elizabeth's emotional breakdown on Avery's shoulder is a powerful release of the accumulated sorrow, love, and the weight of what might have been.



CHAPTER 45: SUPPER AT SIX

Avery shares with Elizabeth that Madeline wrote written to Wilson regarding the family tree she created, which was published alongside the *Life* magazine article. Madeline wrote about how Calvin had been raised in a home she believed Wilson was funding. This letter prompted Avery to conduct further investigations, eventually unraveling the story.

Madeline's letter to Wilson is a crucial piece in the puzzle that kickstarted Avery's actions and ultimately led to the uncovering of Calvin's past. Although she is just a child, Madeline is perhaps the figure most responsible for bringing her family together.



Curious, Elizabeth asks about Calvin's biological father. Avery reveals that he died from tuberculosis before Calvin was born. Then she shares the story of their meeting. In turn, Elizabeth recounts her own first encounter with Calvin. Avery expresses a desire to learn more about Calvin and to be a part of Elizabeth's family. Elizabeth warmly responds, affirming that Avery is already family.

Avery's disclosure of Calvin's biological father's fate, succumbing to tuberculosis before Calvin's birth, adds a layer of tragedy to Calvin's backstory. However, it also lifts the oppressive lie that the bishop told Calvin—that is, that Calvin's father hated him.



As Avery prepares to leave with Wilson, Elizabeth extends an invitation to them for “supper at six” at her home lab. She includes Walter, Harriet, Madeline, and Six-Thirty in the invitation and mentions that they should also meet Dr. Mason and Wakely soon because she considers them family. After Avery and Wilson depart, Elizabeth and Six-Thirty return to the lab and begin researching abiogenesis.

Elizabeth's response to Avery's wish to be part of her family is a gesture of acceptance. Likewise, the inclusion of Walter, Harriet, Madeline, Six-Thirty, Dr. Mason, and Wakely in Elizabeth's circle reflects the idea that her family extends beyond biological relationships. For Elizabeth, a one's family includes those one loves and cares for, regardless of genetic makeup.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Sawyer, Ian. "*Lessons in Chemistry*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 8 Jan 2024. Web. 8 Jan 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Sawyer, Ian. "*Lessons in Chemistry*." LitCharts LLC, January 8, 2024. Retrieved January 8, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/lessons-in-chemistry>.

To cite any of the quotes from *Lessons in Chemistry* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Garmus, Bonnie. *Lessons in Chemistry*. Doubleday. 2022.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Garmus, Bonnie. *Lessons in Chemistry*. New York: Doubleday. 2022.